

AI for the Rest of Us

AI for the Rest of Us

The Plain-English Guide to Getting Real Help From AI, No
Tech Background Required

James Liu

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This book was written with AI assistance under the author's direction, outline, and review. Statistics and case studies are drawn from cited public sources; any claim of personal experience is the author's own.

ISBN: [assigned at KDP publishing step]

For everyone who closed the tab because they didn't know what to type.

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CHAPTER 1

You Don't Need to Be a Tech Person

Linda sat at her kitchen table with her phone propped against the fruit bowl. A cursor blinked in an empty text box. Her granddaughter had set the app up for her the week before, typed in a cheerful example question to show how it worked, and left for college the next morning. Linda had opened the app four times since then. She had typed nothing four times since then.

What she wanted to ask was small. A letter had come from her insurance company, three pages of numbers and terms she didn't recognize, and she wanted to know what it actually meant before she called anyone. But every time she put her thumbs on the screen, the same thought stopped her: what if she asked it wrong. What if there was a correct way to do this that everyone else already knew, and typing the wrong way would somehow show.

Linda isn't unusual, and neither is the week she spent avoiding that blank box. She's just a little behind a curve that's moving faster than most people realize.

KEY INSIGHT

49 percent of U.S. adults now use AI chatbots, up from 33 percent just two years earlier. The habit went from a niche behavior to something close to a coin flip in ordinary conversation in a short stretch of time.

Source: Pew Research Center, "Americans' Views on AI Chatbots, Smart Devices and AI's Impact," June 2026.

There is no wrong way to ask. That single fact would have saved Linda a week of a blank text box, and it's the reason this book exists.

1.1 Where the fear actually comes from

Nobody sits down at a landline and worries about dialing it wrong. Nobody hesitates before asking a librarian a question because they're not sure they're "a library person." The hesitation Linda felt at her kitchen table isn't really about the technology. It's about a specific, learned fear: that technology comes with hidden rules, that everyone else got the manual, and that using it wrong will expose something embarrassing about you.

That fear has a real source. A lot of software actually does punish the wrong click. Menus hide the feature you need three folders deep. One wrong setting breaks something else. Years of that experience teaches a completely reasonable lesson: be careful, or you'll make a mess you can't undo.

That lesson doesn't apply here, and it's worth saying exactly why. Typing a question to AI isn't like navigating a settings menu. There's no wrong folder. There's no setting to break. The worst thing that can happen is the answer isn't very good, in which case you say so and ask again, the same way you'd tell a friend "no, that's not quite what I meant" and keep talking. That's not a mistake. That's most of how it's supposed to work.

There is no wrong way to ask.

1.2 What Linda actually typed

Eventually, on the fifth try, Linda typed this: "I got a letter from my insurance company and I don't understand it. Can I show you what it says and you explain it in plain English?"

That's it. Not a special format. No technical terms. She was worried about doing it wrong and what she did was type the exact question she would have asked a friend who worked in insurance, if she happened to have one sitting at her kitchen table. She pasted in a few lines from the letter. The explanation that came back wasn't perfect. One term it defined

a little too generally for her specific policy, and she had to ask a follow-up to pin it down. But within ten minutes she understood the letter well enough to know she didn't actually need to call anyone. The thing she'd been dreading for a week took less time than making the tea she'd been drinking while she dreaded it.

Nothing about that exchange required Linda to know anything about how the technology works. She didn't need to know what a model is, or a token, or a prompt. She needed to know how to describe what she wanted, the same skill she already uses every time she asks a pharmacist a question or explains a problem to a mechanic. That skill was never missing. It was just never pointed at this before.

1.3 Why “not a tech person” is the wrong test

Somewhere along the way, being comfortable with new technology got treated as a personality trait. Some people “are” tech people. Some people “aren't.” It sounds like a fact about you, permanent and a little embarrassing to admit, like being bad at directions.

It isn't a trait. It's exposure. The people who look effortlessly comfortable with a new app aren't smarter or more naturally wired for it, they've just failed at using ten other apps before this one and shrugged it off each time instead of deciding it meant something about them. That's the entire difference. Not aptitude. Just fewer bad experiences logged as evidence against themselves.

This book asks you to borrow that shrug, on purpose, starting now. The first few questions you ask might come back a little off, the way Linda's first answer was slightly too general. That's not a sign you did it wrong. It's the completely normal first round of a conversation, and every chapter after this one exists to make those rounds shorter and the answers more useful, one ordinary task at a time.

What people assume it takes	What it actually takes
Knowing technical terms, like model, token, or prompt	Describing what you want, the way you would explain it to a person
Getting the question exactly right on the first try	Trying, then saying “not quite” and asking again
Being naturally a tech person	Practice: more tries logged, not more natural talent
A hidden manual everyone else already has	No hidden rules. There is no wrong way to ask

FIGURE 1.1. *What Linda was afraid this required, next to what it actually took to write one honest sentence.*

Linda isn’t the only person whose ordinary week runs through this book. Marisol, a hotel front-desk supervisor two states over, raising two kids mostly on her own, hit the exact same wall Linda did, from a different direction entirely. Her hesitation wasn’t about age. It was about time: twelve-hour shifts don’t leave much appetite for figuring out a new tool on top of everything else, and a coworker’s offhand mention of an app during a lunch break was the only push she ever got. Age, a busy schedule, a career spent around people rather than screens, none of it is really the variable that matters. What matters, every single time, is whether someone finally typed the first honest sentence. This book follows both of their weeks, alongside your own, because the fear at that kitchen table wears a lot of different faces and answers to exactly the same fix.

1.4 What this book will not do

A book that promises this will solve everything isn’t a book you should trust, so here’s the honest limit before you read any further.

This book will not replace a doctor, a lawyer, or an accountant, and any chapter that touches health, legal questions, or money says so again in its own words, not just here. What it will do is help you walk into those appointments and conversations with better questions and a clearer sense of what's actually being asked of you, which is a real and different thing from replacing the professional in the room.

It also won't make a confusing situation simple if the situation is genuinely complicated. Some insurance letters really are that complicated, some family situations really do need a human who knows your specific history. What changes is that you'll have a first pass at understanding before you spend money or a favor on someone else's time, not instead of it.

And it won't remove every ounce of the hesitation Linda felt at that kitchen table. New things feel new for a while no matter how many times someone tells you they're simple. What it will do is give you enough small wins early that the hesitation gets quieter each time, the same way it did for Linda somewhere around her third real conversation.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- There is no wrong way to ask. The worst outcome is an answer that isn't quite right, which you fix by saying so.
- "Not a tech person" describes fewer good experiences, not a fixed trait. It changes with practice, not with a personality change.
- You already have the underlying skill: describing what you want in plain language. It just hasn't been pointed at this before.
- This book doesn't replace a doctor, lawyer, or accountant. It helps you walk into those conversations better prepared.

1.5 Where this goes next

Chapter two slows down and looks closely at exactly what Linda typed, and the one habit underneath it that makes every other chapter in this book work: being specific about what you actually want, the way you'd be specific with a person and not a search box. The next several chapters each take on one ordinary task, a trip, a difficult letter, a kid's homework, a doctor's appointment, a confusing bill, in enough detail that you can do the real

version the same week you read it. After that comes the moment it gets something wrong, which will happen, and exactly how to catch it, followed by a chapter on staying safe, because the same technology that helps you also gets used against people, especially people who are new to it, and that chapter doesn't flinch from saying so plainly. From there the book turns practical: which tool to actually use, talking instead of typing, and a longer run of everyday jobs, a big purchase, the words you can't find for a hard occasion, the daily grind of cooking and cleaning, the emergency that shows up without warning, what to do when someone you love won't even try, a job search, the fine print on something you're about to sign, Medicare and insurance choices, a big family gathering. It closes with becoming the person your own family calls, the way you might already call someone else, two families living with all of it for a full season, the honest pushback this book hasn't answered yet, and every template collected in one place at the very end, to keep.

CHAPTER 2

The One Sentence That Changes Everything

A few weeks after the insurance letter, Linda tried something new. She wanted help planning what to cook for a dinner with her son's family, six people, one of them newly vegetarian. She typed: "Give me dinner ideas."

The answer came back fine. Generic, but fine. A list of pasta dishes, a stir-fry, a salad. Nothing wrong with any of it. Nothing that felt like it was actually for her Sunday, either. It read like it could have been written for anyone, because it had been. She'd given almost no information, so there was almost nothing for the answer to be built from.

She tried again. This time: "I'm cooking dinner for six people this Sunday. One of them just went vegetarian and I don't want to make her a separate meal. Give me one main dish everyone can eat, nothing too spicy because my husband can't handle heat."

Same tool. Completely different answer. A specific dish. A reason it worked for a mixed table. A note about where to find a milder version of one ingredient. The second version wasn't a better tool. It was one sentence longer, and that one sentence was the entire difference.

2.1 Why one sentence does that much

Think about what happened between those two questions. In the first one, Linda knew she was cooking for six people, that one of them was vegetarian, that her husband doesn't like spicy food. All of that was true and sitting in her head the whole time. None of it made it into the question. The tool never had it, so it couldn't use it, the same way a friend couldn't help plan the meal if Linda called and only said "give me dinner ideas" and hung up before saying anything else.

This is really the whole chapter, so it's worth saying it plainly. **The AI can only work with what you actually tell it.** Not what you're thinking. Not what seems obvious to you. What you typed. When an answer feels generic, that's almost never the tool being bad at its job. It's the question being a smaller version of what you actually meant, and the answer coming back exactly as small.

KEY INSIGHT

Nielsen Norman Group, a usability research firm that has studied how people use technology for decades, tested how prompt specificity changes an AI tool's output and built their published "CARE" framework around the same finding: a prompt carrying real context, who it's for, what you're actually trying to do, produces results people rate as far more usable than a vague one-liner carrying none of it.

Source: Nielsen Norman Group, "CARE: A Structure for Crafting AI Prompts," nngroup.com, 2025.

2.2 The one sentence, broken down

Linda's second try wasn't complicated. It just answered three quiet questions that the first version left blank.

Who's it for? Six people, one vegetarian. Not "dinner," dinner for this specific table.

What actually matters here? One dish everyone can eat, nothing separate to cook. That's the real goal, not just "ideas."

What should it avoid? No heavy spice, because of her husband. A boundary the tool would never have guessed on its own.

That’s the whole method. Not a formula to memorize, just a habit: before you hit send, picture explaining the same thing to a person standing next to you, and notice what you’d naturally add that you almost left out of the typed version.

Question	Your answer
Who is this actually for?	
What actually matters here?	
What should it avoid?	

FIGURE 2.1. *The three-question habit from this chapter, turned into a fill-in template. Answer these before you type, on paper or in your head, and watch the next answer get sharper.*

The AI can only work with what you actually tell it.

2.3 You don’t need a perfect first try

It’s worth saying clearly: Linda didn’t get the good version on her first attempt, and that’s completely normal, not a sign she did it wrong. The first, vague question wasn’t a failure. It was a first draft, the same as anyone’s first draft of anything. The fix wasn’t starting over. It was adding the three things she already knew and just hadn’t said yet.

This matters because a lot of people quietly decide, after one generic answer, that the tool “doesn’t really work for this.” Usually what happened is closer to Linda’s first try: a real question, just a smaller one than the real

question in her head. One more sentence, and the same tool answered the actual question instead.

2.4 Marisol's version, the same habit at work

Marisol hit the exact same wall a week later, from a different direction. She needed a quick note to Diego's teacher explaining he'd miss a day for a family event, typed "write a note excusing my kid from school," and got back something so generic it could have excused any child from anything, three sentences of nothing in particular. She caught herself doing what Linda had done, adding the three missing pieces on the second try: who it was for (Diego, third grade, his specific teacher's name), what actually mattered (one day, a family event, nothing requiring a doctor's note), and what to avoid (anything that sounded overly formal for a note to a teacher she saw at pickup most days). The second version read like an actual parent wrote it, because an actual parent had, just with three sentences' worth of help finding the words.

2.5 Where this stops helping

Being specific isn't a magic trick that fixes everything, and it's worth saying where its limits are before moving on. If you genuinely don't know what you want yet, "help me figure out what I want" is itself a fine, honest place to start, and a good back-and-forth conversation can help you get more specific as you go. You don't need to arrive with a perfect, fully-loaded question. You just need to notice, a few messages in, whether you're still being vague about something you actually do know, and fill that in when you notice it.

And no amount of specificity turns a wrong answer into a right one. Chapter eight is entirely about catching the times an AI tool states something confidently that just isn't true, which happens regardless of how well you asked. Specificity gets you a much better answer. It doesn't get you a guaranteed one, and the next few chapters build the habit of checking, not just asking better.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- A generic answer almost always means a small question, not a bad tool. The AI can only use what you actually typed, not what you were thinking.
- Add the three things you already know: who or what it's actually for, what really matters here, and anything it should avoid or watch out for.
- Your first try doesn't need to be perfect. A vague first question is a normal first draft, not a mistake, fixable with one more sentence.
- Being specific gets you a much more useful answer. It doesn't guarantee a correct one, that's a separate skill covered later in this book.

2.6 Where this goes next

Chapters three through seven each take this same habit into one real, ordinary task: planning a trip, writing the letter you've been avoiding, helping with a kid's homework, walking into a doctor's appointment prepared, making sense of a confusing bill. You'll see the same pattern in each one, a vague first try and a specific, better second one, because it's genuinely the same skill every time, just pointed at a different Sunday.

CHAPTER 3

The Trip You Haven't Had Time to Plan

Linda's daughter had been asking for two months: when are you and Dad finally taking that anniversary trip you keep talking about. Linda kept saying soon. What she meant was that she'd opened a travel site four different times, gotten overwhelmed by a wall of hotel options she had no way to compare, and closed the tab each time without booking anything. The trip wasn't stalled because she didn't want to go. It was stalled because planning it felt like a part-time job she hadn't signed up for.

KEY INSIGHT

Research from Priceline found the average traveler spends the equivalent of two full working days, around sixteen hours, researching and booking a single trip. Other surveys put the number even higher once comparison shopping and reading reviews are included.

Source: Priceline Press Center, "New Priceline Research Finds Average Traveler Spends Two Full Work Days To Plan and Book Trips."

Sixteen hours is a lot to ask of anyone's evenings, and it explains exactly why Linda's tab kept closing. This chapter isn't about replacing the trip itself, the choosing of where to go and what matters to you about it. It's about the sixteen hours of comparing, cross-referencing, and re-reading the same five hotel descriptions that stand between "we should go" and an actual booking.

3.1 What Linda actually did

She started smaller than a whole trip. One evening, she typed: “We want to go somewhere for our anniversary in October, five nights, warm weather, budget around three thousand dollars for two people including flights from Chicago. We like walking around a city more than sitting on a beach all day, and we don’t want anywhere that requires a long layover. Give me three destination options and why each one fits.”

That single message did the job of the first several hours of research, the part that isn’t really about any one hotel, it’s about narrowing an entire world of possible trips down to three real options worth actually comparing. She picked one of the three, then went back for the next layer: “For [the city she picked], find us a hotel in walking distance of the old town, under two hundred a night, with real recent reviews mentioning it’s quiet at night.” Another few minutes, another few hours of scrolling avoided.

Field	Your answer
Destination or type of trip	
Dates	
Budget, all travelers included	
Who is going	
What matters most (walkable, quiet, relaxed)	
What to avoid (long layovers, beach only, crowds)	

FIGURE 3.1. *The fields behind Linda's trip-planning message, turned into a blank worksheet. Fill in these six things before you open a chat window, the same six she already knew and just had not said yet.*

The tool is excellent at cutting sixteen hours of undifferentiated searching down to twenty minutes of focused comparing.

3.2 Why this works the same way chapter two described

Notice Linda's message wasn't just "plan our anniversary trip," the vague version that would have produced the same generic overwhelm she was already drowning in. It had the three things from chapter two: who it's for (two people, a specific budget), what actually matters (walkable city, not a long layover), and what to avoid (long layovers, beach-only destinations). The trip-planning version of a good question isn't a new skill. It's the same one sentence habit, aimed at a bigger, messier decision than dinner.

3.3 Marisol's version: a smaller trip, the same wall

Marisol's version of this wasn't an anniversary trip, it was a weekend visit to see her sister four hours away, and the wall she hit was smaller but just as real: which route to drive, where to stop with two kids who'd need a break, whether it was worth the extra hour to avoid a stretch of highway construction she'd heard about but hadn't confirmed. She typed: "Driving from [her city] to [her sister's city] this weekend with two kids, ages 10 and 15. Give me a route, a good stopping point roughly halfway for a break, and whether the construction on [the highway] is worth avoiding." Ten minutes, not sixteen hours, because the decision was smaller, but the exact same shape: specific origin and destination, who's actually along for the ride, and

the one real constraint worth asking about by name instead of hoping it wouldn't matter.

3.4 What to still do yourself

This chapter will not tell you to book a hotel sight unseen because a chatbot recommended it, and it's worth saying exactly where the line sits. Use it to narrow a wall of hundreds of options down to a short, sensible list. Then do what you'd always do with a short list: look at real photos, check the reviews yourself on a site you trust, confirm the actual price on the booking site directly before you pay anything. The tool is excellent at cutting sixteen hours of undifferentiated searching down to twenty minutes of focused comparing. It's not a replacement for your own eyes on the final choice, and treating it as one is exactly the kind of over-trust chapter eight covers in detail.

And never hand over a credit card number or personal details inside the chat itself. Use it to research and narrow down, then go to the actual airline, hotel, or travel site to book and pay. Chapter nine goes further into why that boundary matters, but it's worth planting here, on the first task in this book that involves real money.

3.5 Why this isn't cheating or lazy

If narrowing a big decision down with a few typed sentences feels like it should require more effort to count as "real" planning, that instinct is worth questioning directly. Nobody thinks asking a knowledgeable friend "where should we go for a week in October, we like walking around cities" is lazy. It's exactly what people have always done, they just usually didn't have a friend who happened to know hundreds of cities' walkability and weather patterns off the top of their head. The travel agent industry existed for exactly this reason for decades before anyone had a chat window. This is that same help, available on a Tuesday night at 9 p.m. instead of during a travel agency's business hours.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- Planning a single trip takes the average traveler around sixteen hours. Most of that time is spent narrowing an overwhelming set of options, not deciding between two final choices.
- The same one-sentence habit from chapter two applies here: who it's for, what matters, what to avoid, aimed at a trip instead of a dinner.
- Use the tool to narrow hundreds of options to a short list. Do the final check yourself: real photos, reviews on a trusted site, the actual price on the actual booking site.
- Never enter payment details inside the chat itself. Research and narrow there, then book and pay on the real airline, hotel, or travel site directly.

3.6 Where this goes next

Chapter four turns to a different kind of task, the letter you've been avoiding, a difficult message rather than a big decision, but built on the exact same habit: be specific about the situation, and let the tool do the part that used to eat your whole evening.

CHAPTER 4

The Letter You've Been Avoiding

The mattress arrived with a six-inch tear along one seam, foam showing through like a wound. Linda called the company, sat on hold for forty minutes, and was told a technician would need to “assess the damage” before anyone talked about a refund. She hung up, put the phone in the kitchen drawer she uses for takeout menus and old warranty cards, and didn’t touch the problem again for eleven days.

It wasn’t that she didn’t know what to do. She knew exactly what to do. Somewhere, sometime, she’d have to write the company a firm letter, on the record, that laid out the timeline and asked for the refund in plain terms. She just couldn’t make herself sit down and do it. Every time she thought about starting, her mind went to the sentence would sound too angry, or not firm enough, or she’d forget some detail that mattered and undercut her own case. The letter itself was maybe fifteen minutes of typing. The dread in front of it was eleven days.

Across town, Marisol was avoiding a different letter. Her apartment’s heat had been cutting out since October, and her landlord’s response every time she called was some version of “we’ll send someone.” Nobody came. She’d started three different texts to him, each one either too apologetic or too sharp, and deleted all three. She knew tenants had rights here. She did not know how to write the message that used them without sounding like she was starting a fight she couldn’t afford to lose. She has two kids and one landlord who controls where they sleep. That’s not a letter you draft twice at eleven at night and send without flinching.

KEY INSIGHT

When U.S. consumers filed a written complaint with the Consumer Financial Protection Bureau in 2025, companies gave a timely response more than 99 percent of the time, and the large majority closed with an actual explanation or some form of relief, not silence. The fear that a written complaint disappears into a void is common and usually wrong.

Source: Consumer Financial Protection Bureau, Consumer Response Annual Report, March 2026.

That statistic is about financial complaints specifically, not mattresses or landlords, but the pattern it describes holds more broadly than the fine print suggests: a written complaint that states what happened, when, and what you want, gets treated differently than a phone call that trails off in frustration. Most people who avoid writing the letter aren't avoiding the writing. They're avoiding the fear that firmness will backfire, and that fear is exactly what this chapter helps with.

4.1 What actually happens when the words won't come

Notice what Linda and Marisol were both stuck on. It wasn't the facts. Linda knew the delivery date, the tear, the useless phone call. Marisol knew the months, the broken thermostat, the unanswered texts. What stalled both of them was tone: how do you say "fix this" firmly enough to be taken seriously, without sounding like you've lost your temper, when you're not sure yourself where that line is.

This is a genuinely useful thing to hand to an AI tool, because tone is exactly the kind of judgment call it's good at helping calibrate, once you tell it what you're actually worried about.

Linda typed: "I need to write a firm complaint email to a mattress company. They delivered a damaged mattress on [date], I called on [date] and was told someone would assess the damage, and eleven days later nobody has contacted me. I want a full refund, not a repair or exchange. Write it firm and clear, not angry, and end with a specific date I expect to hear back by."

What came back wasn't a letter she could send unedited. It never is, and that's fine. But it did the two things she'd been stuck on: it stated the facts

in order without editorializing, and it landed exactly where she wanted on tone, firm without sounding like a threat. She changed two sentences to sound more like her own voice, added the order number, and sent it that afternoon. The refund was processed six days later.

Most people who avoid writing the letter aren't avoiding the writing.

4.2 Marisol's version, and where she went further

Marisol's message needed something Linda's didn't: she genuinely didn't know what her rights were as a tenant, only that she probably had some. So her first message to the AI tool wasn't a request to draft anything. It was a question: "I'm a tenant in [her state]. My landlord hasn't fixed my heat since October despite repeated calls. What are my rights here, in plain English, and what's the strongest thing I can reasonably put in writing to him?"

The answer gave her something concrete to work with: many states require a landlord to maintain a habitable unit, heat included, and a written notice with a specific repair deadline is usually the step that matters most if the issue ever needs to go further, to a housing authority or small claims court. That single fact changed what she wrote next, from a message she'd have sent to a friend into a message she'd have wanted a lawyer to see: dated, specific about the exact dates she'd called, and closing with a real deadline for a response.

This is worth saying plainly: an AI tool giving you a general answer about tenant rights is not the same as a lawyer reviewing your specific lease and your specific state's law, and Marisol's message said "in plain English" for a reason, not "tell me exactly what to do." Where the stakes are genuinely high, an eviction notice, a lease dispute already heading to court, a specific legal deadline, that general answer is a place to start getting oriented, not a place to stop. Chapter seven says the same thing about money questions, for the same reason.

4.3 Try this: your own stuck letter

Think of the letter, text, or email you’ve been putting off, the one sitting in a mental drawer the way Linda’s phone sat in the kitchen one. Before you open a chat window, answer three things on paper first, the same three questions from chapter two aimed at a harder task:

Who is this actually going to, and what do they need to understand fast? What outcome do you actually want, stated as a specific thing (a refund, a repair by a date, an apology, a correction), not just “for this to be handled”? And what tone do you want, described in your own words: firm but polite, formal, warm but clear?

Type those three things into the chat along with the plain facts, in order, with dates where you have them. Read what comes back once for accuracy and once for whether it sounds like something you’d actually send. Edit the parts that don’t sound like you. That’s the whole method, and it works whether the letter is about a mattress, a landlord, a school, or an insurance company.

Question	Linda’s answer, for the mat-tress letter
Who is this actually go-ing to?	The mattress company, referenc-ing the delivery date, the tear, and the unanswered call
What outcome do you want?	A full refund, not a repair or an exchange
What tone do you want?	Firm and clear, not angry, ending with a specific reply-by date

FIGURE 4.1. *The three questions from this chapter, answered for Linda’s actual mattress letter: the same three worth answering before you open a chat window for your own.*

4.4 Why this doesn't replace the hard conversation

There's a version of this chapter that promises the AI tool removes the discomfort of confrontation entirely, and that promise would be dishonest. It doesn't. Marisol still had to send the message to her actual landlord and live with whatever he said back. Linda still had to decide, on her own, that a refund and not a replacement was the right ask. The tool removes the specific friction of staring at a blank box not knowing how to start, and it's genuinely good at calibrating tone once you describe what you're going for. It does not make the underlying situation easier, and it doesn't negotiate on your behalf. You're still the one who has to mean what the letter says.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- A written complaint gets a response far more often than the fear suggests. The blank-page dread is usually bigger than the actual risk of writing it.
- What stalls most people isn't the facts, it's tone: how firm is too firm. Tell the AI tool the tone you're going for and let it calibrate a draft, then edit it back into your own voice.
- For a general rights question ("what can I ask for here"), a plain-English answer is a fine starting point. For anything with real legal stakes, that answer is where you start getting oriented, not where you stop.
- The tool removes the blank-page problem. It doesn't remove the conversation itself. You still have to send it and mean it.

4.5 Where this goes next

Chapter five stays close to home in a different way: the homework a kid brings to the kitchen table, and the specific worry that using AI to help means you're doing it for them. The answer isn't as simple as "never" or "always," and the chapter walks through exactly where that line sits.

CHAPTER 5

Homework Help Without Doing the Homework

Marisol's son Diego, ten years old, slid his math worksheet across the counter the way he always does when he's stuck: not asking for help exactly, just leaving it there and hoping. Fractions. Word problems about pizza, which is always pizza, as if no other food divides. She used to be fine at this kind of math. She is less fine at it after a twelve-hour shift, at eight at night, with dinner dishes still in the sink.

Her first instinct was to type the whole problem into a chat window and read Diego the answer. She stopped with her thumb over the screen. That felt like cheating, not for her, for him, and she couldn't quite say why except that it felt true the way a lot of parenting worries feel true before you've thought them all the way through.

What she typed instead was this: "My ten-year-old is stuck on a fractions word problem about splitting pizza between friends. Don't give me the answer. Ask him one question at a time to help him figure it out himself, like a patient tutor would." She read the first question out loud to Diego. He got quiet, thought about it, and answered it. The AI's next question built on his answer. Four questions later, he solved it himself and looked almost annoyed that it had been that simple.

5.1 The line, stated plainly

Here is the actual line, the one Marisol was reaching for without the words for it yet: using AI to give your kid the answer is doing the homework for them. Using it to ask your kid the questions a good tutor would ask, so they arrive at the answer themselves, is not. The difference isn't the tool. It's which side of the desk the tool is sitting on.

	Giving the answer	Asking the questions
What the AI does	States the answer directly	Asks one question at a time
What your kid does	Copies it down	Thinks, answers, builds the idea
Is it their homework?	No	Yes

FIGURE 5.1. *The line this chapter draws, laid out side by side: which side of the desk is the tool sitting on?*

KEY INSIGHT

More than half of U.S. teens, 54 percent, say they’ve used an AI chatbot for help with schoolwork, and a majority of teens, 59 percent, believe using AI to cheat has become a normal, regular part of student life now. The anxiety this chapter addresses isn’t hypothetical. It’s already the water kids are swimming in.

Source: Pew Research Center, “How Teens Use and View AI,” February 2026.

That second number is the one worth sitting with. If most teens already believe AI-assisted cheating is normal, the question isn’t whether your kid

will encounter this pressure. It's whether they learn, at your kitchen table, what the honest version of using the tool looks like, before they learn the dishonest version from a classmate who just wants the worksheet done by nine.

The difference isn't the tool. It's which side of the desk the tool is sitting on.

5.2 What this looks like with an older kid

Linda's granddaughter Sofia, fifteen, was stuck on an essay about the causes of the American Revolution, not because she didn't understand the material, but because she'd been staring at a blank document for forty minutes and every draft she started felt wrong. Linda, watching her granddaughter's frustration build over a Sunday visit, suggested trying the same question-first approach Marisol had used with Diego, adjusted for a teenager who needed a different kind of help: not tutoring on the facts, but a way past the blank page.

Sofia typed: "I'm writing a history essay on the causes of the American Revolution. I understand the material but I'm stuck starting. Ask me questions about what I think the strongest cause was and why, don't write any of the essay itself, just help me find my argument." Fifteen minutes of back and forth later, she had an argument she actually believed (that the taxation disputes mattered less on their own than the sense of being governed without any say at all) and she wrote the essay herself, in her own words, starting from an idea she'd found through the questions rather than been handed.

The essay was hers. Every sentence in it came from her. What the AI tool did was closer to what a good writing tutor does in office hours: ask the questions that help a stuck student find their own argument, then get out of the way.

5.3 The honest exception: explaining something once, plainly

Not every homework moment is about building an argument or solving a fraction step by step. Sometimes a kid just needs a concept explained once, clearly, the way you'd explain it if you remembered the material yourself. "Explain what a noun clause is, with three simple examples, the way you'd explain it to a ten-year-old" isn't tutoring toward an answer they need to produce themselves. It's the AI equivalent of pulling out a reference book, and there's nothing dishonest about a kid using a reference book. The line stays in the same place either way: explaining a concept is fine, generating the actual assignment text for them to copy is not.

5.4 Try this: the tutor prompt, adapted to your kid

The exact wording that worked for both Diego and Sofia, adaptable to any age and any subject: "My [age]-year-old is working on [subject/assignment]. Don't give the answer directly. Ask one question at a time to help them figure it out themselves, and adjust the difficulty based on how they respond." Keep that sentence somewhere you'll actually find it again, a notes app, a sticky note by the computer, because it's the one sentence in this whole chapter worth reusing verbatim, every time, for years.

5.5 What to say if the school has a policy

Many schools now have explicit rules about AI use on assignments, and those rules vary school to school and even teacher to teacher. Before using any of this on a specific assignment, especially with an older kid, check what's actually allowed for that class. The tutoring approach in this chapter, using AI to ask questions rather than produce answers, is honest by design, but "honest by design" and "matches your kid's specific teacher's specific policy" aren't automatically the same thing, and it's worth five minutes to make sure they line up before homework night, not during it.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- The line is simple to state even if it's not always simple to hold: AI giving the answer is doing the homework. AI asking the questions a good tutor would ask is not.
- The exact prompt to reuse: "Don't give the answer directly. Ask one question at a time to help them figure it out themselves."
- Explaining a concept plainly, once, is closer to a reference book than to doing the assignment. Generating text for a kid to copy into their own work is not.
- Check your specific school's AI policy before using this on graded work. The method here is honest by design, but school rules vary and it's worth five minutes to confirm.

5.6 Where this goes next

Chapter six moves from a kitchen-table worry to a waiting-room one: walking into a doctor's appointment with the right questions already in hand, and exactly where the line sits between being prepared and asking a chatbot to do a doctor's job. It's the same discipline as this chapter, wearing a different coat: help that prepares you, never help that replaces the person whose actual job it is.

CHAPTER 6

Walking Into the Doctor's Office Prepared

Linda's husband Hal had a follow-up appointment after a scan came back with a word neither of them recognized: a finding on his kidney, small, probably nothing, but the kind of "probably" that keeps you up at eleven at night reading forums you shouldn't be reading. The appointment was fifteen minutes long. Linda knew from the last three appointments how fast fifteen minutes goes once a doctor starts talking, and how much of it turns into a blur the second you're in the room and scared.

She sat down the night before with the printout from the scan, the parts she could actually read, and typed: "My husband's kidney scan mentioned this finding: [she pasted the exact phrase]. We have a follow-up appointment tomorrow. Help me understand, in plain English, what this might mean and what the range of possibilities is, and give me five specific questions to ask the doctor so we don't leave the appointment more confused than we walked in." She wasn't asking for a diagnosis. She was asking for a translation and a question list, the two things a fifteen-minute appointment rarely leaves room to build from scratch in the room itself.

The explanation helped her understand the term well enough to follow the conversation instead of just nodding through it. The five questions were sharper than what she'd have thought of on her own, standing in the room, watching Hal's face. One of them, "is this something that needs monitoring on a schedule, or a one-time follow-up," turned out to be exactly the question the doctor needed to answer for them to actually understand the plan. They

asked all five. They left with real answers instead of a vague sense of relief that the appointment was over.

KEY INSIGHT

A Brown University study that recorded 189 real doctor's visits found patients accurately recalled only 49 percent of the decisions and recommendations made, without prompting, right after the appointment ended. Prompted, that rose to 85 percent. The gap between those two numbers is almost entirely the difference between walking in with questions already written down and walking in hoping you'll remember to ask.

Source: Laws et al., "Factors associated with patient recall of key information in ambulatory specialty care visits," PLOS ONE, February 2018.

That's not a small gap. It's the difference between an appointment that actually changes what you understand and one that mostly just happened to you.

6.1 Where the line is, said as plainly as this book says anything

This is the chapter where the limit matters more than anywhere else in this book, so it's worth saying it three separate times in three separate ways before moving on. An AI tool is not a doctor. It has not examined your husband. It does not have his full history, his other medications, the look on his face the doctor would notice in the room. What it can do is exactly what Linda used it for: turn confusing language into plain language, and turn "I don't know what to ask" into a list of specific, good questions. What it cannot do, and should never be asked to do, is tell you what's wrong or what to do about it. That's the doctor's job, every time, no exceptions, no matter how confident or specific the AI's answer sounds.

That's not a small gap. It's the difference between an appointment that actually changes what you understand and one that mostly just happened to you.

6.2 Marisol's version: a symptom, not a scan

Marisol had been getting headaches most afternoons for three weeks, the kind that started behind one eye and made the light in the break room feel too bright. She almost didn't book an appointment at all. It's a headache, everyone gets headaches, and taking a half day off an hourly job to talk to a doctor about a headache felt, to her, like it might be an overreaction she couldn't afford, both in time and in the awkwardness of explaining herself.

What she typed wasn't a request for a diagnosis, and she knew better than to ask for one. It was: "I've had a headache most afternoons for three weeks, starts behind my right eye, worse by evening, better after I sleep. I have an appointment Thursday. What questions should I make sure I ask so the doctor has enough to actually figure out what's going on, and is this the kind of thing worth taking time off work for?" The answer didn't diagnose anything, and it said so directly, more than once. It did help her notice a pattern she hadn't put into words yet, that the headaches seemed to track with days she'd skipped lunch, and it gave her a specific way to describe the timing that made the appointment far more useful than "I've been getting headaches" would have.

She went. It turned out to be dehydration and low blood sugar from a work schedule that didn't leave time to eat, an unglamorous answer, and also the correct one, caught faster because she walked in with a pattern already described instead of a vague complaint.

6.3 What never to type into a symptom checker

There's a specific trap worth naming directly, because it's an easy one to fall into with exactly this kind of tool: typing a symptom in and asking "what disease is this," expecting a diagnosis back. Even when an AI tool gives you a confident, specific-sounding answer to that question, treat it the way you'd treat a stranger's guess in a waiting room, mildly interesting, not a reason to act. The honest, useful question is never "what do I have." It's "what should I ask about, and how do I describe this clearly." That reframe alone keeps you on the right side of the line every time.

6.4 After the appointment matters too

Preparation doesn't end when the appointment does, and it's worth naming the second half of chapter six's own research: recall fades fast once the visit is over, the same forgetting curve that made preparation matter in the first place. Linda started doing one more small thing on the drive home, or right in the parking lot before pulling out: talking through what she'd just heard into a voice memo, or typing a quick summary into the same chat window, "Here's what the doctor just told us: [her rough notes]. Help me organize this into a clear summary I can reference later and share with Hal's other doctors if needed." Ten minutes, captured while it was still fresh, turned a fading memory into something durable enough to actually reference weeks later, at the next appointment, when someone inevitably asked what the specialist had said and the honest answer would otherwise have been a shrug.

6.5 Try this: the appointment-prep prompt

Before your next appointment, big or small, try this: "I have an appointment about [symptom or finding, described specifically]. Help me understand what I've described in plain English if there's anything confusing about it, and give me [4-5] specific questions to make sure I ask so I don't leave more confused than I came in." Bring the questions on paper or your phone. Ask all of them, even the one that feels like it might be a silly question. It usually isn't.

Field	Your answer
Symptom or finding, described specifically	
Question 1 to ask	
Question 2 to ask	
Question 3 to ask	
Question 4 to ask	
What to bring (scan, medication list, notes)	

FIGURE 6.1. *A blank appointment-prep sheet, built from this chapter’s own prompt. Fill it in the night before, the same way Linda did for Hal’s follow-up.*

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- An AI tool cannot diagnose you and should never be asked to. What it can do well is translate confusing medical language and help you build a sharp, specific list of questions before you walk in.
- Patients forget half of what they're told in an appointment without a written list of questions to anchor the conversation. Preparation, not memory, is what makes the fifteen minutes count.
- The honest question is “what should I ask about,” never “what do I have.” That single reframe keeps you on the right side of the line every time.
- This is not a diagnosis, does not replace a professional, and this chapter means that every time it says it, not just here.

6.6 Where this goes next

Chapter seven takes the same kind of quiet dread, the questions you're embarrassed to ask because everyone else seems to already know the answer, and points it at money instead of medicine. Same fifteen-minutes-of-fog problem. Same fix: get plain-English clarity before the conversation that matters, not during it.

CHAPTER 7

Money Questions You're Embarrassed to Ask

Marisol's new job offered two health insurance options during open enrollment, a page of terms she half-recognized and half-didn't: deductible, coinsurance, out-of-pocket maximum. She'd had insurance for years and still couldn't have told you, with confidence, what the difference between a deductible and a copay actually was. Everyone around her at work seemed to just know, comparing plans on their lunch break like it was nothing, and asking out loud felt like announcing something about herself she didn't want announced.

She didn't ask a coworker. She opened a chat window on her break and typed: "Explain deductible, coinsurance, and out-of-pocket maximum like I've never seen an insurance form before. Then look at these two options [she typed out the numbers from the enrollment page] and tell me what questions I should be asking myself to pick between them, not which one to pick, just what actually matters here." Nobody watched her type it. Nobody knew it was a question she felt she should already know the answer to. Ten minutes later she understood the difference well enough to compare the two plans against what she actually needed: fewer doctor visits, but her younger kid saw a specialist twice a year, and that changed which plan made sense.

KEY INSIGHT

In the Federal Reserve's 2025 survey of household finances, 63 percent of U.S. adults said they could cover a \$400 emergency expense using cash or its equivalent, meaning more than a third could not. If a plain money question feels embarrassing to ask out loud, it's worth remembering that a real, sizable share of the room would be in the same position.

Source: Federal Reserve Board, "Report on the Economic Well-Being of U.S. Households in 2024," May 2025.

That number is worth sitting with for a second, because the shame around not understanding money is almost always private and almost never accurate. More than a third of adults would be caught out by the same \$400 surprise Marisol has budgeted around for years. Financial confusion isn't a sign you're behind. It's close to the median experience, just one nobody says out loud at the office.

7.1 What this actually helps with, and what it doesn't

An AI tool is genuinely useful for exactly the thing Marisol used it for: explaining a term you're embarrassed not to know, running the numbers on a comparison you could technically do yourself but keep putting off, or helping you understand a bill or a form well enough to ask the right follow-up question. It is not a financial advisor, it doesn't know your full financial picture unless you tell it everything relevant, and it should never be the final word on a decision with real consequences, how to invest retirement savings, whether to refinance a house, how to handle a tax problem that's already escalated. For those, "helps me understand the options well enough to talk to a real advisor" is the right frame, the same not-a-replacement line chapter six draws around doctors, drawn here around anyone whose actual job is giving financial advice.

Financial confusion isn't a sign you're behind. It's close to the median experience, just one nobody says out loud at the office.

7.2 Linda's version: the question she'd been avoiding since Hal's last birthday

Linda had a specific number stuck in her head and no idea whether it meant anything: the age Hal could start claiming Social Security versus the age that would get him a bigger monthly check if he waited. Everyone at their community center seemed to have a confident opinion about when to claim, most of them contradicting each other, and Linda had stopped bringing it up at their table because she didn't actually understand the tradeoff well enough to argue either side.

She typed: "My husband is 63 and can start Social Security anytime between now and 70. In plain English, what's the actual tradeoff between claiming earlier versus later, and what personal factors should we be weighing, not what we should decide?" What came back wasn't a recommendation, and it said so directly. It explained the basic mechanics, an earlier claim means a smaller check for life, waiting increases it up to age 70, and named the real personal factors the confident opinions at the community center never mentioned: health and family longevity, whether one spouse earns significantly more, whether either of them planned to keep working past 63. That framing turned a vague, embarrassing gap into a short, specific conversation Linda and Hal could actually have with each other, and later with the Social Security Administration's own free benefits counselors, who deal with exactly this question all day.

Term		What it actually means
Deductible		What you pay yourself before insurance starts paying anything
Coinsurance		The percentage you keep paying after the deductible, insurance covers the rest
Out-of-pocket maxi- mum		The most you'll pay in a year total; insurance covers 100% after that
Claiming age (Social Security)		Earlier claim = smaller check for life; waiting until 70 = the largest possible check

FIGURE 7.1. *Four terms behind two of this chapter’s questions, decoded once so you don’t have to ask twice.*

7.3 When the number itself feels shameful, not just confusing

Some money questions aren’t about jargon at all, they’re about a number that already feels like a verdict on how well you’ve managed things: credit card debt that’s grown quietly for years, a retirement account that never got started. Marisol carried a balance she’d stopped opening the statement for, the shame of the number itself bigger than any confusion about what it meant. “I have [amount] in credit card debt at roughly [rate]. In plain English, what are the realistic ways people typically pay this down, and what should I understand before choosing one?” didn’t erase the number or the discomfort of it. It turned a feeling of vague, paralyzing shame into an actual short list of real approaches, worth bringing to a nonprofit credit counselor, several of which exist specifically to help without charging for the conversation, rather than a number she kept avoiding entirely because looking at it felt worse than not knowing.

7.4 Try this: the plain-English money prompt

Whatever the specific question is, a form, a bill, a comparison between two options, an unfamiliar term on a pay stub, the same shape of prompt works: “Explain [the specific term or document] like I’ve never seen this before. Then help me think through [the specific decision or comparison], not by telling me what to pick, but by telling me what actually matters here.” That second half matters as much as the first. It keeps the tool in the role of clarifying your options rather than making the decision for you, which is exactly the role it’s actually good at.

7.5 Why “just ask a friend” doesn’t fully solve this

It’s a fair question: couldn’t Marisol have just asked a coworker, and couldn’t Linda have just called her sister? Sometimes, yes, and a real conversation with someone who knows you is still worth more than any chat window, especially for a decision this personal. But the private, judgment-free version matters for a specific reason: it removes the moment of exposure, the flush of admitting out loud that you don’t already know something everyone else seems to. For some people that moment isn’t a big deal. For plenty of others, it’s exactly the thing that’s kept a real, answerable question unanswered for years, quietly, at a real cost.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- More than a third of U.S. adults couldn't cover a \$400 emergency expense in cash. Financial confusion is closer to normal than it feels when you're the one who doesn't understand the form.
- AI is genuinely good at explaining terms and running comparisons in plain English. It is not a financial advisor, and it should never be the last word on a decision with real, lasting consequences.
- The right frame for anything high-stakes: "help me understand this well enough to talk to a real advisor," not "tell me what to do."
- A private, judgment-free first pass removes the exposure of admitting you don't already know something. That alone unblocks questions that sit unanswered for years.

7.6 Where this goes next

Chapter eight turns to the moment this whole book has been quietly building toward: what happens when the AI tool gets something wrong, confidently, in a way that sounds exactly as certain as the answers that were right. It's the single most important habit in this book, and it applies to every chapter that came before it.

CHAPTER 8

When It Gets It Wrong

Linda asked a simple question about Hal's new blood pressure medication: could he take it with his regular allergy pill. The answer came back fast, specific, and confident, naming an interaction between the two drugs that sounded exactly like the kind of precise detail a trustworthy answer would have. She almost just told Hal what she'd read. Something made her pause, the same instinct that once made her double-check a recipe that seemed to be missing a step, and she asked their pharmacist instead. The pharmacist had never heard of that interaction. It didn't exist. The AI tool hadn't hedged, hadn't said "I'm not certain," hadn't sounded any different from the dozen other times it had been exactly right. It had simply been wrong, with total confidence, and Linda had almost acted on it.

This is the chapter every other chapter in this book has been quietly pointing toward. Being specific, chapter two's whole argument, gets you a much better answer. It does not get you a guaranteed one. No chapter in this book, including this one, can promise you an AI tool will never be confidently, plausibly, specifically wrong. What this chapter can do is give you the habit that catches it when it happens, before it costs you something.

8.1 The pattern, and why your instincts alone won't catch it

KEY INSIGHT

Wharton researchers ran experiments with over 1,300 participants and found people accepted a correct AI answer 93 percent of the time, and accepted a wrong AI answer, delivered with the same confident tone and no caveats, 80 percent of the time. The researchers call this “cognitive surrender”: people don’t just trust AI, they borrow its confidence, without checking whether that confidence is earned.

Source: Shaw and Nave, “Thinking, Fast, Slow, and Artificial,” Wharton School research, 2026.

Read that gap again: 93 percent versus 80 percent. If an AI tool sounded less certain when it was wrong, the way an honest person’s voice sometimes wavers on a guess, this would be a much smaller problem. It doesn’t sound less certain. A wrong answer and a right answer can sound, word for word, identically sure of themselves. That’s the actual trap, and it’s not a character flaw in the people who fall for it. It’s a completely reasonable response to a tool that has been right often enough to earn trust, delivering a wrong answer in exactly the voice of a right one.

A wrong answer and a right answer can sound, word for word, identically sure of themselves.

8.2 Marisol’s version: smaller stakes, same pattern

Marisol asked whether the library near her apartment was open on Sundays, planning to take Diego there after his soccer game. The answer said yes, ten to four, specific hours, no hesitation. They drove over. The library was closed on Sundays, and had been for over a year, since a budget cut Marisol vaguely remembered hearing about and had forgotten. Diego was

disappointed. It cost them forty minutes and a wasted trip, not a medication error, but the exact same failure: confident, specific, wrong, and nothing about how it was said that would have tipped her off.

That's worth noticing on purpose: the pattern doesn't only show up on high-stakes questions. It shows up on library hours and restaurant addresses and whether a store still carries something, just as easily as it shows up on a drug interaction. The habit that catches it has to be a habit, not a special alarm you only switch on when the topic feels important, because by the time a wrong answer sounds important, you've usually already half-believed it.

8.3 The habit that actually works

Here's what would have caught both of Linda's and Marisol's mistakes, and it's a genuinely small habit, not a research project every time you ask a question: for anything where being wrong would cost you money, time, or your health, check the specific, checkable fact against one more source before you act on it. Not the whole answer, usually. Just the specific claim doing the load-bearing work: the drug interaction, the library hours, the price, the deadline. A second's search, a phone call, a pharmacist, a real hours listing.

This isn't "don't trust AI." It's the same habit you'd already use with any other single source: one confident voice, checked once, before it changes something real.

Situation	The fact that mat-tered	Checked before acting?
Linda’s blood pressure question	Whether the two drugs actually inter-act	No. She almost told Hal, then asked the pharmacist and learned the interac-tion didn’t exist
Marisol’s library question	Whether the library was actually open on Sunday	No. They drove over and found it closed, it had been for over a year

FIGURE 8.1. *The two-question check, run against what actually happened to Linda and Marisol, with a blank row ready for the next answer you’re not sure whether to trust.*

8.4 A quick way to tell when you’re at risk

The moment to be most careful is exactly the moment an answer feels most reassuring: specific, confident, exactly what you were hoping to hear, and delivered fast. That combination feels like relief, and relief is precisely when people stop checking. Slow down for one extra question in that specific moment, not because the answer is more likely to be wrong then than any other time, but because it’s the moment you’re least likely to notice if it is.

8.5 Try this: the two-question check

Before acting on anything specific and consequential an AI tool told you, ask two questions of yourself, not the tool: What’s the one fact in this answer

that, if wrong, would actually matter? And have I checked that one fact anywhere else? If you can answer both honestly, in most cases the fact is small enough that being wrong costs you little, or you've already checked it. When you can't answer either one, that's the moment to check before you act, not after.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- AI can be confidently, specifically, plausibly wrong, and nothing about how it sounds will tip you off. A wrong answer and a right one can be delivered in the exact same tone.
- Research on “cognitive surrender” found people accept wrong AI answers 80 percent of the time when delivered with confidence, only slightly less than the 93 percent acceptance rate for correct answers.
- The fix isn't distrust, it's one habit: for anything that would cost you money, time, or health if wrong, check the one load-bearing fact against a second source before you act.
- The moment you're most at risk is the moment an answer feels most reassuring. That's exactly when people stop checking, and exactly when it's worth one more question.

8.6 Where this goes next

Chapter nine goes further into a related but sharper danger: the same technology that helps you also gets used against you, by people who know exactly how convincing a confident, specific-sounding message can be. This book doesn't flinch from saying so plainly, and neither does the next chapter.

CHAPTER 9

The Scams and the Sketchy Stuff

Linda's phone rang at 6:40 in the morning, her grandson's number on the screen, and a voice that was unmistakably his, panicked, saying he'd been in a car accident and needed bail money wired immediately, please don't call Mom, he'd explain later. Linda's hand was already reaching for her purse before a second thought caught up with the first: her grandson was fifteen. He didn't have a car. She hung up and called her daughter, who confirmed he was asleep upstairs, safe, and had never made that call.

Nothing about the voice had sounded wrong. That's the part worth sitting with. It wasn't a bad impression, or a stranger's voice pretending, the way an old scam might have sounded slightly off if you listened closely. It sounded like him, panic and all, because it had been built from him: pulled from a video he'd posted online, run through a tool that can now clone a convincing voice from three seconds of audio. Linda didn't catch this one because the voice gave anything away. She caught it because the story didn't add up, and she stopped to check before she acted, the same habit chapter eight just spent a whole chapter building.

KEY INSIGHT

In 2025, Americans age 60 and older reported more than \$7.7 billion in fraud losses to the FBI's Internet Crime Complaint Center, and for the first time, the agency tracked AI-enabled fraud specifically: more than 3,100 complaints from seniors referencing AI, with losses topping \$352 million. The report names voice cloning used to impersonate a family member in distress, exactly Linda's call, as one of the specific tactics now driving that number.

Source: FBI Internet Crime Complaint Center, 2025 Elder Fraud Report.

This chapter will not soften that number to make the rest of the book feel more comfortable. The same technology helping you write a letter or plan a trip is available, right now, to people using it to convince someone's grandmother that her grandson is in a jail cell. Saying that plainly is the only honest way to write this chapter.

9.1 Why this specifically targets older adults, and what to do with that

It's not an accident that older adults are targeted harder. Scammers running these calls are optimizing for exactly two things: someone likely to have money set aside, and someone less likely to have already heard about this specific scam. Neither of those is about intelligence or carelessness. Being newer to a piece of technology, or less exposed to the latest version of a scam, is not a character flaw, and if you're reading this chapter as the older adult in your own family, nothing about falling for this once, or almost falling for it, says anything about you except that you hadn't heard about this particular trick yet. Now you have.

The same technology helping you write a letter or plan a trip is available, right now, to people using it to convince someone's grandmother that her grandson is in a jail cell.

9.2 The one habit that catches almost all of it

Here it is, stated as plainly as chapter eight's habit: if anyone calls, texts, or emails asking for money, gift cards, wire transfers, or account information urgently, especially tied to a family emergency, hang up or stop replying, and contact that person directly through a number or method you already know and trust, not the number that called you. Every version of this scam depends on you acting inside the panic, before you have time to verify. The moment you step outside that call and check independently, the scam almost always falls apart in seconds, exactly the way Linda's daughter's sleeping son settled it in one text.

That's it. That's the whole defense, the same shape as chapter eight's habit aimed at a sharper danger: don't verify the story from inside the call. Verify it from outside, through a channel the caller doesn't control.

9.3 Marisol's version: protecting the other direction

Marisol's worry ran the other way. Her mother, seventy-eight, lives alone two states away and has started getting calls Marisol only hears about after the fact, a "grandson" asking for money, a "bank" asking her to confirm her account number. Marisol couldn't be in the room for every call. What she could do was have one direct conversation, and she used an AI tool to help her prepare it, the same way chapter six used one to prepare for a doctor's appointment rather than to replace the doctor.

She typed: "Help me write a short, warm, non-alarming script I can use to talk to my 78-year-old mother about phone and text scams, especially the kind where a caller's voice sounds exactly like a family member's. I don't want to scare her or talk down to her. I want her to know the one thing to do if it happens: hang up and call me directly." What came back gave her a starting point she reshaped in her own words, warmer, shorter, with an actual joke her mother would recognize as coming from her. The script wasn't the point. Having one, instead of winging a hard conversation in the moment, was.

9.4 The sketchy stuff beyond phone calls

Voice cloning is the sharpest version of this, but it's not the only one. Fake customer service numbers that show up first in a search result. Texts claiming to be a delivery company needing you to "confirm your address" through a link. AI-written emails that no longer have the spelling mistakes that used to be the easy tell. The underlying rule is the same across every version: urgency plus a request for money, access, or personal information is the pattern, regardless of the specific costume it's wearing that week. Learn the pattern once, and it covers scams that haven't been invented yet.

9.5 What a real message from your bank actually looks like

One more specific pattern worth naming, because it's common enough to deserve its own line: a text or email claiming to be your bank, asking you to click a link and "verify" your account. A real bank does not ask you to confirm your password, PIN, or full account number by text or email, ever. If a message claims to be your bank and asks for exactly that, it isn't your bank. Close it, and if you're genuinely unsure, call the number printed on the back of your actual card, never a number or link inside the suspicious message itself.

Warning sign	What to do instead
A family-emergency call demanding money, gift cards, or a wire transfer, urgently	Hang up. Call that person back on a number you already have, not the one that called you
A text or email asking you to click a link and confirm your account	Close it. A real bank never asks for a password, PIN, or full account number this way
Any urgent request for money, gift card codes, or account access	Verify through a channel the caller doesn't control before doing anything else
A family-emergency call that doesn't know your family password	That's your answer, before you've said a word back

FIGURE 9.1. *The pattern underneath every scam in this chapter, urgency plus a request for money or access, and the one response that defeats all of them.*

9.6 Try this: the family password

A specific tool worth setting up before you need it, not after: agree on a word or short phrase with the people you'd trust to call you about a real emergency, something a scammer voice-cloned from a public video would have no way to know. If a "family emergency" call doesn't include it, that's your answer before you've said a word back.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- Seniors reported over \$7.7 billion in fraud losses in 2025, and voice-cloned “family emergency” calls, built from as little as three seconds of public audio, are a specifically named, fast-growing tactic.
- A cloned voice can sound exactly right. It’s the story, not the sound, that gives it away, if you stop to check.
- The core defense: verify through a channel the caller doesn’t control, not the number that called you. Hang up and call back directly.
- Falling for this once, or almost falling for it, is not a character flaw. It’s a sign you hadn’t heard about this specific trick yet. Set up a family password before you need one.

9.7 Where this goes next

Chapter ten turns from safety to practicality: which tool to actually use, and how to set it up sensibly, the question this book has quietly assumed an answer to for nine chapters. From there, a longer run of chapters takes on more of the ordinary jobs on your list, before this book closes the loop it opened with Linda’s blank text box: becoming the person your own family calls.

CHAPTER 10

Choosing and Setting Up Your Tool

This book has quietly assumed something for nine chapters: that you already have some AI chat app open on your phone or computer. For Linda, her granddaughter set it up before leaving for college. For Marisol, a coworker mentioned an app one lunch break and she downloaded it that afternoon without thinking much about it. Neither of them chose their tool the way you'd choose a car or a phone plan, weighing options. They just started with whatever landed in front of them, and it worked out fine, which is itself worth knowing before this chapter gets into any specifics: the tool matters much less than the habits this book has spent nine chapters building. Still, if you're starting from nothing, or wondering whether the one you have is the right one, this chapter is the plain-English version of that decision, with no seventeen-tab comparison chart.

10.1 The short answer, if you want to stop reading here

Download one well-known AI chat app, ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini, or Copilot are the four you'll see mentioned most, made by OpenAI, Anthropic, Google, and Microsoft respectively, use the free version, and start with chapter two's one-sentence habit on something small. That single sentence is 90 percent of what this chapter has to tell you. The rest is for the specific questions that come up once you've started.

A single demo question proves the app opens. It doesn't teach anyone how to use it, and Linda spent a week alone with a blank box because a demo question was all she got.

10.2 The four, honestly compared

None of these four requires a card on file to try, and every one of them changes its exact free-plan numbers often enough that any figure printed here will drift, so treat what follows as the shape of the honest trade-off, not a number to memorize. What's stable enough to rely on:

ChatGPT (OpenAI) has the largest free tier of the four and, as of this writing, gives free accounts unlimited ordinary text conversation, with separate, smaller daily limits on things like image uploads and generated pictures. It's the one most people have already heard of, which makes it a reasonable default if you have no other reason to pick.

Claude (Anthropic) caps free use by a rolling daily message count rather than by feature, and is frequently noted for producing longer, more carefully organized answers on the free tier, useful for the kind of multi-step help this book leans on, an appointment-prep list, a full trip itinerary. The tighter daily cap is the real trade-off against ChatGPT's more generous one.

Gemini (Google) signs in with the same account as your email if you already use Gmail, which is a genuine convenience, not a marketing point, and integrates directly with Google Docs, Sheets, and Drive if you use those. Its free tier is generous for ordinary chat.

Copilot (Microsoft) is the only one of the four that works with no account or sign-in at all, at copilot.microsoft.com or built into some Windows computers already. That makes it the fastest way to try this book's habits on a borrowed or public computer, with the trade-off that skipping sign-in also means no memory of past conversations between sessions.

KEY INSIGHT

All four major AI chat tools offer a genuinely usable free tier as of 2026, not a crippled trial: unlimited or near-unlimited text conversation is the current norm rather than the exception it was a few years earlier. Every specific limit named above is the kind of detail that changes with the next product update, on all four tools, without warning.

Source: verified against each provider’s own current pricing and help documentation at writing time; re-verify before relying on a specific number, not just the general shape.

None of that is a strong enough difference to lose sleep over. If you already have one because a family member set it up, or your phone came with one built in, that’s a perfectly good reason to just use that one rather than researching further. Pick one, use it for a month, switch if something about it genuinely bothers you.

Tool	Made by	Worth knowing
ChatGPT	OpenAI	Largest free tier; the one most people have already heard of
Claude	Anthropic	Free tier capped by daily message count, not feature; often longer, more organized answers
Gemini	Google	Signs in with your existing Google account; connects to Docs, Sheets, Drive
Copilot	Microsoft	Only one of the four with no sign-in required at all

FIGURE 10.1. *The four most-mentioned AI chat tools, compared honestly. Exact free-tier limits change often enough not to print here; what’s stable is the shape of each trade-off.*

10.3 Free versus paid, in plain terms

Every major AI chat app has a free version, and for everything this book covers, a trip, a letter, homework help, appointment prep, a budget question, the free version is genuinely enough. The paid versions, usually \$20 a month, mostly buy you faster responses, higher usage limits if you're using it heavily every day, and access to the company's newest, most capable model a little sooner. None of that changes whether the tool can help Linda write a complaint letter or help Marisol understand a pay stub. Start free. If you find yourself hitting a daily limit because you're genuinely using it constantly, that's the signal to consider paying, not a guess made in advance.

10.4 What to actually check before you type anything personal into it

This is the one piece of setup worth taking seriously, not skipping past: before you paste anything sensitive, a full account number, a medical record number, a child's full name and school, into any AI chat tool, know two things. First, most of these tools, by default, may use what you type to improve their systems, which is not the same as a stranger reading it, but is also not the same as a private conversation with a person who forgets it the next day. Second, every major tool has a setting, usually under "Settings," "Privacy," or "Data Controls," to turn this off. Take five minutes the first time you set up any of these tools to find that setting and turn it off if it bothers you. It doesn't cost anything and it doesn't make the tool work any worse.

None of the tasks in this book require typing in a full account number or a full legal name and address together. Chapter three's trip-planning example never needed a real credit card number, because the tool only narrows options, you book on the real airline or hotel site. Keep that same instinct everywhere: type what a helpful stranger would need to help you, not what only your bank needs to know.

10.5 Setting it up so it remembers what matters

Most of these tools have a “memory” or “custom instructions” feature, a place where you can tell it a few standing facts about yourself once instead of repeating them every time: your general location, that you prefer short, plain-English answers, that you have two kids of a certain age if homework help is a regular thing. Find that setting once, spend five minutes filling it in, and every future conversation starts a little further ahead. This is the single most useful five minutes of setup in this whole chapter, and it’s the one people skip most often because it looks like an optional extra rather than the actual time-saver it is.

10.6 Talking instead of typing

Linda’s sister Rose has arthritis in both thumbs, the kind that makes a full afternoon of typing feel like a chore before it’s even a task. When Linda taught her the letter-writing habit from chapter four, she watched Rose wince at the third sentence and finally said, “Why are you typing all this? Just talk to it.” Rose looked at her like she’d suggested something faintly ridiculous. Then she tried it, out loud, describing the mattress-company problem the way she’d describe it to a friend on the phone, and the app turned her spoken words into text on the screen as fast as she could talk, no thumbs involved at all.

A real number of people reading this book will find that talking is not a workaround for typing. It’s the better version, full stop, and nobody tells you that up front because typing is what the demos always show. Stiff fingers and hand fatigue are the obvious reasons, but they’re not the only ones: plenty of people simply talk faster than they type, small phone screens make typing genuinely harder for anyone, and some of the tasks in this book, describing a health symptom, working through a hard message, come out more naturally spoken than typed.

KEY INSIGHT

A controlled usability study comparing five ways of getting text into a phone found that older adults (60 to 84) typed noticeably slower than younger adults on a touchscreen keyboard, tracing, and handwriting, but the two groups performed equally fast and equally accurately using voice input. Both age groups also rated voice among their most preferred methods, on par with a physical keyboard.

Source: Amanda L. Smith and Barbara S. Chaparro, "Smartphone Text Input Method Performance, Usability, and Preference With Younger and Older Adults," Human Factors, 2015.

All four tools from earlier in this chapter now offer a genuine spoken conversation mode, not just voice-to-text, one where you talk and the app talks back, hands and eyes free the whole time: look for a waveform or headphone icon near the message box, separate from the keyboard's own microphone key, usually labeled "Voice" or "Live." Every phone's own keyboard also has a plain voice-typing microphone, present system-wide on both iPhone and Android, that turns speech into text you can review before sending, a smaller step than a full voice conversation but available everywhere typing is, not just inside an AI app.

Nothing about chapter two's core habit changes when you talk instead of type, but talking naturally pulls you toward doing it well without trying. Rose's spoken version of her mattress complaint came out as a full, natural account, dates and all, because that's how people talk when they're explaining a real problem to another person.

Voice input struggles in a loud room or anywhere with real background noise, and it occasionally mishears a name or unusual word, worth a two-second glance before sending rather than assuming it heard you perfectly. Neither is a reason to abandon it. The other awkwardness is purely social: talking to your phone out loud in a waiting room can feel exposing in a way typing doesn't. There's no fix for that beyond permission to skip it in public and save it for somewhere private.

10.7 If you're setting this up for someone else

If you're the family member doing what Linda's granddaughter did, here's the one adjustment worth making that she didn't: don't just install the app

and type one example question to show it works. Sit down with the actual person for their first real question, the way chapter thirty describes doing it properly, later in this book. A single demo question proves the app opens. It doesn't teach anyone how to use it, and Linda spent a week alone with a blank box because a demo question was all she got.

10.8 Try this

Whichever of the four you land on, the next time you catch yourself avoiding a task in this book because typing it out feels like too much, tap the microphone instead and just talk through it the way you'd explain it to a person standing next to you.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- One well-known free app is enough to start. The specific choice among ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini, and Copilot matters far less than actually using it, and each has one honest, stable trade-off worth knowing rather than a specific number worth memorizing.
- Paid tiers buy speed and higher limits, not better help with the tasks in this book. Start free; upgrade only if you're genuinely hitting a daily limit.
- Find the privacy setting that controls whether your conversations train the system, and turn it off if it bothers you. Fill in the "memory" or "custom instructions" setting once; it's the highest-value five minutes of setup most people skip.
- Voice input isn't a fallback for people who struggle with typing. Research shows people of all ages rate it among their most preferred ways to get text into a device. All four tools now offer a full spoken conversation mode, not just voice-to-text.

10.9 Where this goes next

Chapter eleven takes the habits built so far and points them at a run of ordinary jobs this book hasn't covered yet, starting with the specific kind of overwhelm that shows up whenever a purchase is big enough to actually worry about getting wrong.

CHAPTER 11

Big Purchases Without the Overwhelm

The washing machine died on a Saturday, the way appliances always seem to, mid-cycle, with a smell Marisol didn't like and a puddle she liked even less. She needed a new one within the week, two kids and a laundry pile don't negotiate, and she opened a shopping site to a wall of models: forty-some options, star ratings that all hovered around the same four and a half, specs in a language that assumed she already knew what a "agitator" was and why she should care whether hers had one.

This is a different kind of overwhelm than chapter three's trip planning, not sixteen hours of research so much as a wall of near-identical options with no obvious way to tell them apart, and a purchase big enough that getting it wrong is a real, expensive mistake, not a suboptimal Tuesday. The method is close cousin to chapter three's, though: narrow first, verify second, never skip the second step.

11.1 What Marisol actually typed

"I need a new washing machine this week, top-load, budget under \$700, for a household of four including two kids, so it needs to handle a lot of loads without breaking down often. I don't need smart features or an app, just something reliable. What should I actually be looking for, and can you

give me three specific things people commonly get wrong when buying one so I don't make the same mistakes?"

That last part, the common-mistakes question, did more work than the first part. The answer explained that for a busy household, load capacity and a solid reliability track record matter far more than the extra cycle options most models advertise, and that one commonly overlooked mistake is not checking the actual interior drum measurements against your biggest regular load, towels and bedding specifically, which is exactly the kind of specific, checkable detail a wall of star ratings would never have surfaced on its own.

KEY INSIGHT

In a 2025 survey of over 21,000 consumers, 95 percent said they regularly read product reviews as part of shopping, and reviews specifically influence larger purchases the most: the more expensive the item, the more people research before buying it. For cars specifically, 80 percent of buyers consult reviews before deciding. The instinct to research a big purchase carefully isn't overcautious, it's close to universal, and an AI tool is a way to do that research faster, not a way to skip it.

Source: PowerReviews, "The Ever-Growing Power of Reviews," 2025 consumer survey.

The tool got them unstuck. It didn't make the decision.

11.2 The part this chapter will not let you skip

Here is where the honesty this book keeps promising matters most: an AI tool does not know which specific washing machine will still be running in four years. It doesn't have access to this month's actual sale prices, doesn't know about a recall that happened last Tuesday, and can be confidently, specifically wrong about a model number or a spec, exactly the failure chapter eight spent a whole chapter on. What it's genuinely good at is exactly what it did for Marisol: turning "forty options I can't tell apart" into "three or four worth actually comparing," and telling you what actually matters for your situation versus what's just marketing.

After that, do what Marisol did next: she looked up the two finalists on a source she trusted for appliance reliability specifically, read a handful of real recent reviews, mentioning her exact concern (a household that does laundry constantly, not occasionally), and checked the current price on the actual retailer's site before buying. The AI tool got her from forty to two in fifteen minutes. The last fifteen minutes of actual verification were still hers to do, the same non-negotiable line chapter three drew around booking a hotel.

11.3 Linda's version: a bigger number, a longer runway

Linda and Hal had been putting off replacing their car for over a year, the kind of purchase big enough that “we’ll figure it out eventually” kept quietly winning against any actual research. What finally got Linda to open a chat window wasn’t a breakdown, it was boredom on a rainy afternoon, and a question that had been sitting unasked for a year: “We’re looking at replacing our car in the next few months, mostly for local errands and occasional trips to see our daughter three hours away, nothing about towing or off-roading. Budget around \$28,000. What questions should we be asking ourselves before we even start looking at specific models, and what’s actually worth prioritizing for how we’d use it?”

The answer reframed the decision usefully: for their actual use, mostly short trips with one longer highway drive a few times a year, reliability and highway comfort mattered more than the towing capacity and cargo space Hal had been fixated on from a truck commercial he’d half-watched months earlier. That reframing, done in ten minutes on a rainy Sunday, did more to move the decision forward than the year of vague “we should look into it” conversations that preceded it. They still spent two weekends test-driving actual cars before buying anything. The tool got them unstuck. It didn’t make the decision.

11.4 Negotiating, once you’ve actually narrowed it down

For purchases where the price itself is negotiable, a car especially, the narrowing conversation naturally leads to a second, different one: what’s actually a fair starting offer. “I’m looking at a [year, make, model] priced at [amount] with [mileage/condition]. In plain English, what’s a reasonable target price range for this, and what’s a respectful way to open a negotiation without insulting the seller?” doesn’t replace the actual back-and-forth, which still happens face to face, in person, the way it always has. It replaces walking in with no sense at all of what a fair number even looks like, which is usually the thing that makes the whole negotiation feel more intimidating than it needs to be.

What actually matters	What’s usually just marketing
Load capacity and a solid reliability track record for your household	Extra wash cycle options most models advertise
Interior drum size against your actual biggest load, towels and bedding	Smart features and an app you don’t need
Reliability and highway comfort for how you’ll actually drive	Towing capacity and cargo space sized for a trip you don’t take
Recent reviews and today’s actual price, checked yourself	The overall star rating alone

FIGURE 11.1. *What Marisol’s washing machine search and Linda’s car search actually turned on, once the marketing noise was stripped away.*

11.5 Try this: the narrow-then-verify prompt for any big purchase

“I need to buy [item] within [timeframe], budget around [amount], mainly for [how you’ll actually use it]. What actually matters for my situation, what’s just marketing, and what do people commonly get wrong buying this kind of thing?” Then take whatever short list comes back and do the fifteen minutes of real verification yourself: recent reviews from a source you trust, the actual current price, and for anything with a safety component, a genuine recall check.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- The overwhelm of a big purchase is usually a wall of near-identical options, not a lack of information. An AI tool is good at narrowing that wall to a short list worth actually comparing.
- Ask what people commonly get wrong, not just what to buy. That question surfaces the specific, checkable details a wall of star ratings won’t.
- The AI tool doesn’t know this month’s prices, a recent recall, or which specific unit will hold up in your house. Verify the finalists yourself before you buy, every time.
- Being stuck for a year and being stuck for fifteen minutes are the same problem at different scales. The same narrow-then-verify method works on both.

11.6 Where this goes next

Chapter twelve turns from the practical to the personal: the eulogy, the wedding toast, the sympathy card, the message you’ve rewritten nine times and still can’t send. Different kind of stuck than a washing machine wall of options, and the chapter treats it that way.

CHAPTER 12

The Words You Can't Find

Linda's father-in-law died on a Thursday, and by Saturday she'd been asked to say a few words at the service, the kind of ask that arrives already assuming yes. She had forty years of memories and not one sentence. Every draft she tried on paper came out either too formal, a stranger's eulogy for a stranger's grandfather, or too raw, more grief than the room could hold at ten in the morning on a Saturday. She sat with a blank page for two hours the night before and produced nothing she could stand to read out loud.

This chapter exists for exactly that two hours, and for every smaller version of it: the sympathy card where "sorry for your loss" feels too thin, the wedding toast that needs to be funny and sincere in the same three minutes, the birthday message for someone you love where "happy birthday" alone feels like showing up empty-handed. These are not tasks with a right answer to look up. They're tasks where you know exactly what you want to say and the words simply won't come, which is a completely different kind of stuck than anything else in this book.

12.1 What Linda actually did, and what she didn't

She didn't ask an AI tool to write her father-in-law's eulogy. That would have handed the hardest, most personal task to a machine that never met him, and read as exactly that at the service, generic warmth standing in for forty years nobody else in that room had lived. What she did instead was closer to what a good editor does: she talked through three specific

memories out loud into her phone, unstructured, some of it barely making sense, the way grief talks. Then she asked the AI tool to help her find the shape underneath what she'd said: which memory to open with, how the three pieces might connect, whether four minutes of rambling could become ninety seconds that actually landed.

What came back wasn't her eulogy. It was scaffolding built entirely from her own words, rearranged and tightened, not one new sentence of content added. She rewrote most of it again in her own voice before the service, cutting a transition that felt too smooth for how she actually talks, keeping the structure. What she read out loud on Saturday was unmistakably hers, about her father-in-law, in a voice only someone who'd known him forty years could have written. The tool didn't supply the memories. It helped her find the shape she couldn't see in her own exhausted, grieving 11 p.m. draft.

The tool didn't supply the memories. It helped her find the shape she couldn't see in her own exhausted, grieving 11 p.m. draft.

12.2 The line, for this chapter specifically

Every chapter in this book has drawn some version of a line, and this one matters as much as any of them: an AI tool can help you find the shape of something you already feel and can't organize. It should never generate the feeling itself. A eulogy, a wedding toast, a sympathy message, these only mean something because they came from someone who actually knew the person, actually feels the thing being said. Ask the tool to invent a fond memory you never had, and even if nobody in the room could technically prove it was borrowed, you'd know, and that knowledge would sit wrong under every future memory of the moment. The honest use is always the same shape: you supply the real material, spoken, messy, unstructured if that's how it comes out. The tool helps you find where it wants to go.

12.3 Marisol's version: smaller, still real

Marisol's best friend from high school had a miscarriage, and Marisol wanted to send something better than the card-aisle default, something that actually said she remembered how badly her friend had wanted this. She typed, into the chat, three true things: how long her friend had been trying, a specific conversation they'd had about names, and the fact that Marisol didn't know the right thing to say and didn't want to pretend she did. She asked for help turning those three true things into a short message, not a poem, not something that sounded like a greeting card, something that sounded like her.

What she sent was four sentences. It named the actual conversation about names. It didn't try to make anything better, because nothing could, and it said that plainly instead of reaching for comfort it didn't have. Her friend called her that night, not to talk about the message specifically, just to talk, which is probably the actual measure of whether four sentences did their job.

12.4 When it's a happy occasion instead of a hard one

Not every version of this chapter is grief. A toast, a birthday message, a note tucked into a graduation gift all hit the same blank-page wall for a happier reason: the words matter enough that the ordinary, generic version feels like it undersells how much you actually mean it. Hal's retirement-dinner toast from chapter fifteen used exactly this three-true-things method, three specific memories of a forty-year friendship rather than a generic "he'll be missed," and the room laughed at the right moment because the memory was real and specific, not because a joke had been engineered to land. The method doesn't change with the occasion. Only the true things being gathered do.

12.5 Try this: the three-true-things method

Whatever the occasion, a toast, a card, a hard message you can't find the opening line for, start the same way Linda and Marisol both did without

planning it that way: say or write down three specific, true things, unpolished, in whatever order they come out. A memory. A detail only you would know. The thing you actually feel, stated plainly, even if it’s “I don’t know what to say.” Then ask the AI tool to help you find the shape connecting those three things into something you could actually say out loud or send. Rewrite the parts that don’t sound like you. The true things were always the hard part, and they were always yours. This just finds the shape faster than a blank page at 11 p.m. usually lets you.

The three true things	Write yours here
A memory	
A detail only you would know	
What you actually feel, stated plainly	

FIGURE 12.1. *Blank space for your own three true things, the same raw material Linda’s eulogy and Marisol’s card both started from. Fill it in before you open the chat window.*

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- An AI tool can help you find the shape of something you already feel. It should never generate the feeling, memory, or fondness itself. The room, or the reader, will know the difference even when they can't say how.
- Start with three true, specific, unpolished things, spoken or typed messily. That raw material is the part only you can supply, and it's the part that actually matters.
- What comes back is scaffolding, not a finished piece. Rewrite anything that doesn't sound like your own voice before you say or send it.
- This works at every scale, a four-sentence card and a four-minute eulogy alike. The method doesn't change. Only how much raw material you start with does.

12.6 Where this goes next

Chapter thirteen comes back down from the emotional to the everyday: the ordinary grind of meals, laundry, and a to-do list that never quite empties, and the smaller, steadier ways this same set of habits helps there too.

CHAPTER 13

Cooking, Cleaning, and the Rest of the List

None of the tasks in this chapter are dramatic. That's the point of it. Most of this book has been about the moments that stall you, a scary letter, a doctor's appointment, a purchase big enough to worry about. This chapter is about the smaller, duller weight that never really stalls you, it just never lifts: what's for dinner four nights this week, whether the fridge has what a recipe needs, how to actually get a move organized instead of just dreading the boxes, what to do with a closet that hasn't been touched in three years. None of it is urgent. All of it is tiring in a low, constant way that chapter two's specific-question habit turns out to help with just as much as anything more dramatic.

13.1 Marisol's week, condensed

Marisol used to spend Sunday evenings staring into the fridge deciding what the week's dinners would be, usually landing on the same four meals in rotation because deciding felt like its own chore on top of the cooking. One Sunday she typed: "Here's what's in my fridge and pantry right now: [she listed it, roughly, the way you'd describe it out loud]. Give me four dinner ideas for this week using mostly what I already have, quick enough for a weeknight, and kid-friendly for a picky ten-year-old and a less picky fifteen-year-old." Four real dinners, using what she already had, with one

substitution flagged for the picky ten-year-old. Fifteen minutes on a Sunday instead of a slow, low-grade dread every night at five that used to end in the same rotation anyway.

The trick here is the same one from chapter two, restated at a smaller scale: she told it what she actually had and who she was actually feeding, instead of asking the generic “what should I make for dinner” that would have gotten her a generic answer built for nobody’s actual kitchen.

The actual packing was still theirs. Every decision about what to keep was still theirs.

13.2 Linda’s version: the closet that won her a whole Saturday back

Linda and Hal were downsizing, moving from the house they’d raised their kids in to something smaller, and the closet in the spare room had become the place everything went to be decided about later. She didn’t ask an AI tool to organize her closet, it can’t see it, but she used it the way you’d use a friend who’s good at logistics: “We’re downsizing from a four-bedroom house to a two-bedroom condo in about ten weeks. Help me build a room-by-room plan for what order to tackle things in, and a rough weekly schedule so it doesn’t all pile up on the last weekend.” What came back was a sensible sequence, start with the rooms nobody visits daily, do the sentimental stuff last when there’s already momentum, and a week-by-week schedule that turned “we should really start packing” into six concrete Saturdays with a specific room attached to each one.

The actual packing was still theirs. Every decision about what to keep was still theirs. What changed was the shapeless dread of “we have ten weeks and no plan” becoming six Saturdays with a name on each one, which turned out to be most of the battle.

13.3 The pantry math nobody wants to do by hand

A smaller, more specific version of the same dinner problem: knowing whether what's already in the house is actually enough for the week, or whether Wednesday is going to be a scramble. Marisol started doing a two-minute Sunday inventory, listing roughly what she had on hand, and asking for a shopping list that filled only the real gaps against the week's planned meals, rather than the old habit of a full grocery run every week regardless of what was already sitting in the fridge going unused. It's a small habit, and the effect compounded over months: less food thrown out, a shorter and cheaper cart most weeks, and one less decision made tired in a grocery aisle at the end of a long day.

13.4 The pattern underneath all of it

Every task in this chapter follows the same shape as chapter two's dinner example: describe your actual situation, specifically, the way you'd describe it to a person helping you, and ask for a plan or a short list rather than one right answer. "What's in my fridge" plus "who I'm feeding" plus "how much time I have" beats "what should I make for dinner" every time, for the same reason a specific trip-planning message beat a vague one back in chapter three. None of this is new. It's the same one habit, aimed at the parts of a week nobody writes a book about because no single one of them feels big enough to deserve one.

13.5 Where this genuinely doesn't help

An AI tool can suggest a cleaning schedule, but it can't hold you to it, and a chore chart nobody follows is exactly as useless whether a person or a chatbot wrote it. It can suggest a dinner using what's in your fridge, but it can't taste it, and cooking is still a skill built by cooking, not by reading suggestions. Treat this chapter's tools as what they are: they remove the decision fatigue, the staring-into-the-fridge minute, the where-do-I-even-start minute. They don't remove the doing.

13.6 Try this: the weekly reset prompt

Once a week, at whatever moment the to-do list starts to feel like noise instead of a list, try: “Here’s what’s actually on my plate this week: [list it messily, the way it sits in your head]. Help me sort this into what actually needs to happen this week versus what can wait, and suggest an order to tackle it in.” Fifteen minutes of unloading a cluttered head into a chat window, most weeks, buys back an evening that would otherwise have gone to staring at the list instead of working through it.

Needs to happen this week	Can wait

FIGURE 13.1. *This week’s version of the sorting question the chapter itself asks: what actually needs to happen now, and what can honestly wait.*

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- The small, undramatic weight of ordinary tasks, meals, cleaning, organizing, responds to the exact same specific-question habit as this book's bigger tasks. Describe your actual situation; ask for a plan, not a single answer.
- Naming what you already have and who you're actually serving beats a generic request every time, at any scale, from dinner to a whole move.
- This removes decision fatigue, not the actual doing. A chore schedule still needs following. A recipe still needs cooking.
- A weekly fifteen-minute reset, unloading a cluttered mental list into a chat window, often does more for a busy week than any single big task in this book.

13.7 Where this goes next

Chapter fourteen turns to the moment none of this chapter's calm planning applies: something breaks, goes wrong, or falls apart without warning, and there's no fifteen minutes of quiet Sunday planning available at all.

CHAPTER 14

The Ordinary Emergency

The power went out at 9:40 on a Tuesday night, no storm, no warning, just dark, and Marisol's ten-year-old's insulin needed to stay refrigerated. Not a life-or-death emergency in the next five minutes, but a real one on a clock, the specific kind of ordinary crisis that doesn't wait for a calm Sunday afternoon and doesn't come with a manual. She didn't have her utility company's number memorized. She didn't know how long a closed fridge actually stays cold enough, or what her actual options were at ten at night in a house that had just gone dark.

She typed into her phone, one-handed, the porch light from a neighbor's house the only light in the kitchen: "Power just went out, no storm. I have insulin in the fridge that needs to stay cold. How long does a closed fridge actually stay safely cold, and what should I do right now if it goes longer than that?" The answer came in seconds: a closed refrigerator generally holds a safe temperature for about four hours, longer if you avoid opening the door, and if the outage looked likely to run longer than that, a cooler with ice was the right next move, along with the general safe temperature range to keep the insulin within. She didn't need to know any of that before the outage. She needed it in the next ninety seconds, and got it faster than any phone call, any hold music, any search through old paperwork for a customer service number would have.

14.1 Why this is a different chapter than the rest of the book

Every other chapter in this book has room to slow down: pause, think, ask a follow-up, walk away and come back. This one doesn't, by definition, and it's worth saying plainly what changes when the clock is the actual constraint. Speed matters more than the careful verification chapter eight and chapter eleven both insisted on. Chapter eight is still right that AI can be confidently wrong, and that risk doesn't disappear here. What changes is the tradeoff: at 9:40 on a dark Tuesday, a fast, generally-reliable answer about refrigerator safety beats a slower, more thoroughly verified one you don't have time to get. This is the one place in the book where "good enough, right now" is a genuinely correct choice, not a shortcut you're settling for.

This is the one place in the book where "good enough, right now" is a genuinely correct choice, not a shortcut you're settling for.

14.2 Where the real emergency line sits

Said as plainly as chapter six said it about a doctor's office: for anything that's actually a medical emergency, chest pain, difficulty breathing, a serious injury, a child who's unresponsive, call emergency services first, every time, before typing anything into anything. This chapter is about the enormous category of situations underneath that line: real, urgent, stressful, but not a call-emergency-services situation, where a fast, plain-English answer genuinely helps and a chatbot can give you one faster than searching through old paperwork or waiting on hold.

14.3 Linda's version: locked out, cold, and out of ideas

Linda locked her keys in the car outside the pharmacy, in February, with Hal waiting at home expecting her back for dinner and no way to reach her.

She didn't have a locksmith's number saved, didn't know if her car insurance covered this, and didn't want to just stand in a parking lot being cold and stuck. She typed: "Locked my keys in my car, [make and model], I have AAA membership. What's the fastest way to get help right now, and is this something AAA typically covers?" The answer confirmed AAA roadside assistance almost always covers a lockout, gave her the general number to call, and mentioned it's worth checking her specific membership tier since coverage sometimes varies. She called AAA directly from that answer, in under a minute, instead of digging through her purse for a membership card with a number on the back she could have squinted at just as easily, except she was cold and flustered and the phone answer got her moving faster.

Nothing about that exchange required a chatbot specifically. It required something fast, plain, and immediately actionable, in a moment where digging for the actual answer herself would have cost real minutes standing in the cold.

14.4 What makes an ordinary emergency prompt work

The pattern across both examples: state the actual situation in one sentence, state the actual constraint (a clock, a specific need, what you already have access to), and ask for the next step, not a general explanation. "What should I do right now" beats "tell me about power outages" the same way every specific question in this book has beaten its vague version, just compressed into fewer seconds of typing because that's what the moment allows.

14.5 Try this, before you need it

The best time to think about this chapter is not during the emergency. Take five minutes sometime this week to note, in your phone, the handful of things you'd want fast answers about if something ordinary went wrong tonight: what medications in your house need refrigeration and for how long, your insurance and roadside assistance basics, the non-emergency number for your local police department for something urgent but not a 911 situation. None of that requires an AI tool to gather. It just means that when a Tuesday night goes dark, you're not starting completely cold.

What to note now	Your answer
Medications that need refrigeration, and how long they're safe	
Insurance and roadside assistance basics	
The non-emergency number for your local police department	

FIGURE 14.1. *Five minutes now, filled in before a dark Tuesday, so the next ordinary emergency doesn't start from zero.*

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- For an actual medical emergency, chest pain, trouble breathing, a serious injury, call emergency services first, always, before typing anything anywhere.
- For the much larger category of urgent-but-not-911 situations, a fast, plain-English answer can genuinely help, and speed matters more here than the careful double-checking this book recommends elsewhere.
- State the situation, the constraint, and ask for the next step, compressed into one sentence if that's what the moment allows.
- The best prep happens before the emergency: five minutes now, noting the handful of things you'd want fast answers about later, makes the actual moment less cold and less alone.

14.6 Where this goes next

Chapter fifteen turns to a different kind of hard moment, not a crisis, just a wall: what to actually do when someone you love won't even try any of this, and why pushing harder is usually the wrong response.

CHAPTER 15

When Someone You Love Refuses to Try

Hal wanted no part of any of it. Linda had been using her new habit for months by the time she tried to show him the letter-writing trick from chapter four, hoping to save him the same hour of drafting and redrafting he usually spent on anything official. He waved her off before she'd finished the sentence. "I've written letters my whole life without a computer telling me what to say," he said, not unkindly, just final, the tone of a decision that had already been made a while ago and wasn't up for a rerun. Linda tried twice more over the following month, each time a little more insistent, and each time Hal got a little more dug in. By the third try, it wasn't really about the letter anymore. It was about Linda pushing and Hal resisting, a pattern with a life of its own separate from the actual technology.

This chapter is about that pattern, because it's common, and because pushing harder, the thing that feels most natural when you're certain you're right and certain it would help, is almost always the exact move that makes it worse.

15.1 What's actually happening when someone refuses

It's rarely about the technology itself. Hal's specific words, "I've written letters my whole life," were doing something underneath their literal meaning: protecting a piece of identity, competence with words, that he wasn't

willing to hand over to something that might do it faster or better. Refusing to try isn't usually stubbornness for its own sake. It's much more often a reasonable-feeling defense of a specific fear: that trying and needing help would confirm something the person doesn't want confirmed about themselves, being behind, being old, being less capable than they used to be. Understanding that changes what the right response looks like, because you're not actually arguing about a chat window. You're bumping into something much more personal, and treating it like a simple information gap, "let me just show you how easy it is," almost always misses.

KEY INSIGHT

A 2026 scoping review of digital health technology adoption in older adults found a genuinely two-sided effect from family help: guidance from younger relatives can reduce a person's anxiety about a new technology, but when that help is rushed or delivered impatiently, it does the opposite, increasing anxiety and undermining the person's own sense that the technology is something they could actually use, discouraging them from continuing at all.

Source: Birati and Tzemah-Shahar, "Barriers to Digital Health Adoption in Older Adults: Scoping Review Informed by Innovation Resistance Theory," Journal of Medical Internet Research, 2026.

That finding cuts against the most natural instinct in the room. When someone you love is struggling or resisting, the urge is to move faster, explain more, show them one more time, more clearly. The research says that exact instinct, applied with any hint of impatience, is what closes the door rather than opening it.

The research says that exact instinct, applied with any hint of impatience, is what closes the door rather than opening it.

15.2 What actually worked, eventually, with Hal

Linda stopped bringing it up. Not out of defeat, out of a real change in approach: she decided to let Hal find his own way in, if he ever did, rather

than continuing to make her comfort with the technology into a referendum on his. Two months later, watching her write a birthday message for their granddaughter using the method from chapter twelve, Hal asked, unprompted, whether it could help with the toast he was dreading giving at a friend's retirement dinner. That was the actual opening, not because Linda had finally found the right way to explain it, but because Hal came to it on his own terms, at a moment it solved a problem he already had, rather than a moment Linda had decided was a good time for a lesson.

She sat with him for that one, following the exact same rule chapter thirty lays out properly: he held the phone, he typed his own words, she only helped when he got stuck. It wasn't a triumphant conversion. He still doesn't use it for much. But he uses it for that one thing now, because that one time, it actually helped him with something he actually needed, on a day he'd chosen, not a day chosen for him.

15.3 What to actually do, stated plainly

Stop bringing it up as a topic. Every unsolicited pitch reinforces that this is something you think they're missing, which is exactly the confirmation they're avoiding. Instead, use it naturally, visibly, in your own life, and let curiosity do the inviting instead of persuasion. When they do ask, and many eventually do, resist the urge to make it a full lesson. Answer the specific question, solve the specific problem in front of them, and stop there. Let the next question, if it comes, come on its own schedule.

And if the door never opens at all, that has to be an acceptable outcome, not a project left permanently unfinished. Chapter thirty's whole argument is about becoming the person your family calls. Sometimes what someone needs isn't to be taught, it's to have someone they can still call instead, indefinitely, no pressure attached to eventually learning it themselves. That's not a failure of this book's method. It's a legitimate, permanent answer for some people, and pretending otherwise does nobody any favors.

	What backfires	What actually works
They’ve just said no	Bringing it up again, a little more insistent each time	Using it visibly in your own life and letting curiosity do the inviting
They finally ask a question	Turning it into a full lesson	Answering just that one question, then stopping there
The door stays shut	Treating it as an unfinished project	Being the person they can still call, no pressure attached

FIGURE 15.1. *The one pattern that separated Linda’s first three tries, which made Hal dig in further, from what actually opened the door two months later.*

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- Refusal is rarely about the technology. It’s much more often a defense against confirming something the person doesn’t want confirmed about their own competence.
- Rushed or impatient help from a family member measurably backfires, increasing anxiety and discouraging someone from continuing, according to published research on older adults and technology adoption.
- Stop pitching it as a topic. Use it visibly in your own life and let curiosity, on their own schedule, do the inviting instead.
- If the door never opens, being the person they can still call is a legitimate, permanent outcome, not a failure to eventually fix.

15.4 Where this goes next

A handful of ordinary tasks are still ahead, a job search, a lease or contract worth understanding before you sign it, the small tech problems that have nothing to do with AI and everything to do with a printer that won't connect, something to try purely because you want to, Medicare and insurance open enrollment, a big family gathering. After that comes the chapter this whole book has been building toward: what it actually looks like to become the person your own family calls, done well instead of the well-meaning way that backfires, the way it very nearly did with Hal.

CHAPTER 16

Looking for Work Again

Marisol hadn't updated her résumé since the job she was currently trying to leave, six years of the same bullet points sitting untouched at the top of a document she barely recognized as describing her actual work anymore. The new posting she wanted, a step up, better hours, asked for a cover letter too, and the blank page for that felt worse than the résumé: how do you sell yourself in three paragraphs without sounding like every other cover letter the hiring manager had already skimmed and forgotten that morning.

She'd applied to jobs before by copying the same résumé everywhere and hoping. This time she tried something different, prompted by nothing more sophisticated than exhaustion with the old way. She pasted her rough, outdated résumé and the actual job posting into a chat window and typed: "Here's my current résumé and the job posting I'm applying to. Help me rewrite my bullet points to actually speak to what this posting is asking for, using only things that are true about my real experience, nothing invented. Then help me draft a short cover letter that sounds like a real person, not a form letter."

KEY INSIGHT

Jobscan’s 2025 survey of job seekers found the search dragging on longer than most people expect, with roughly 14 percent of applicants submitting 100 or more applications before landing an offer. A generic résumé blasted out unchanged to every posting is a big part of why: it asks a hiring manager to do the work of translating your experience into their specific need, and most won’t bother.

Source: Jobscan, “The State of the Job Search in 2025.”

16.1 What actually got better, and what didn’t

The rewrite didn’t invent anything. It couldn’t, and she made sure not to let it: every bullet point still described work she’d actually done. What changed was translation, the same six years of experience reframed in the specific language the posting used, “team coordination” instead of the vaguer “worked with others” her old résumé had settled for, because the posting itself used that exact phrase and her actual work matched it precisely. That’s not dishonesty. It’s the same skill a good career coach charges for: hearing what a specific employer is actually asking for and showing them the truest, most relevant version of your real experience.

Only you can vouch for what’s actually true, and every sentence in the final document has to be something you could defend, in detail, to someone’s face.

16.2 The line, and why it matters more here than almost anywhere else

Nowhere in this book does the never-invent rule matter more than here. A résumé is a factual document, and a fabricated skill or an inflated title

isn't a style choice, it's the kind of lie that gets discovered in the first real interview question and ends the conversation immediately, sometimes worse than that. Use an AI tool to reframe, translate, and tighten what's true. Never let it add a certification you don't hold, a title you didn't have, or a skill you can't actually back up if asked about it in the room. The tool doesn't know your real work history. Only you can vouch for what's actually true, and every sentence in the final document has to be something you could defend, in detail, to someone's face.

16.3 Linda's version: coming back after a longer gap

Linda hadn't worked outside the home in eleven years, since before Hal retired, and a friend at church had mentioned a part-time bookkeeping role at a local nonprofit that sounded like a good fit for the skills she'd kept sharp managing the household's finances for decades. The gap felt like the whole problem. How do you explain eleven years on a résumé without it reading as a red flag before anyone's even met you.

She typed: "I haven't worked outside the home in 11 years but have managed complex household finances, budgets, and bookkeeping that whole time. I'm applying for a part-time bookkeeping role. Help me frame this experience honestly on a résumé, and suggest how to address the gap in a cover letter without it sounding like an apology." The answer didn't hide the gap or dress it up as something it wasn't. It reframed the actual, real skill underneath it, eleven years of real budgeting and financial management, just not inside a company, and suggested language for the cover letter that named the gap plainly in one sentence and moved straight to what she'd bring to the role, rather than lingering on an apology nobody needed from her.

16.4 Interview prep, the same tutoring shape as chapter five

The interview itself brought a different kind of nerves, less about what to write and more about freezing up under a question she half-expected but hadn't rehearsed answering out loud. She used the same question-first approach chapter five used for Diego's homework, adapted for herself: "I

have an interview for [the role] on [date]. Ask me common interview questions for this kind of position, one at a time, and after each answer, give me brief, honest feedback on what worked and what I could tighten.” It wasn’t a script to memorize. It was practice, the same way a good manager might run a mock interview, except available at ten at night after the kids were asleep, as many times as she actually needed it, without anyone’s schedule but her own to work around.

16.5 Try this: the translate-don’t-invent prompt

“Here’s my résumé and the job posting I’m applying for. Rewrite my experience to speak directly to what this posting asks for, using only things that are actually true about my background. Then help me draft a short cover letter in a genuine, non-generic voice.” Read every line back afterward and ask yourself the interview-room test: could you explain this exact claim, in detail, to someone’s face. If the honest answer is no, cut it before you send it, no matter how good it sounds.

	Old, generic line	Translated, same true facts
Marisol’s résumé	“Worked with others”	“Team coordination”, the posting’s own phrase, matching work she’d actually done
Linda’s résumé	11 years, no job title, no explanation	11 years managing complex household finances, budgets, and bookkeeping

FIGURE 16.1. Same true facts, translated into the words a posting and a hiring manager actually use. Not one invented skill or title in either line.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- A generic résumé sent unchanged to every posting is one of the biggest reasons a job search drags on. Translating your real experience into each posting's specific language is a skill, not dishonesty, as long as everything stays true.
- Never let an AI tool add a skill, title, or credential you don't actually hold. This is the one chapter in this book where the never-invent rule has the sharpest real consequences.
- A career gap doesn't need an apology. Name it in one plain sentence and move straight to what you actually bring.
- Before sending anything, apply the interview-room test: could you defend every claim on this document, in detail, to someone's face? If not, cut it.

16.6 Where this goes next

Chapter seventeen turns from selling yourself on paper to understanding the paper someone else hands you: a lease, a contract, a set of terms you're about to agree to without reading, and what plain-English help actually looks like there.

CHAPTER 17

The Fine Print

Marisol found an apartment she actually liked, closer to Diego's school, a little more than she wanted to pay but workable, and the landlord handed her a lease twelve pages long, dense with words like "quiet enjoyment" and "subordination clause" that sounded important in a way she couldn't quite pin down. She had twenty-four hours to decide. She skimmed it the way most people skim these things, eyes catching on the rent number and the move-in date, sliding past the rest, and signed it that evening because the apartment was good and the alternative, actually reading twelve dense pages under a deadline, felt like more than she had in her that particular Tuesday.

KEY INSIGHT

A widely cited 2017 Deloitte consumer survey found that 91 percent of people accept a company's terms and conditions without reading them, a figure that climbs even higher, to 97 percent, among adults under 35. The habit of signing first and hoping later isn't unusual or careless. It's close to the default for almost everyone, on almost everything, almost all the time.

Source: Deloitte, 2017 Global Mobile Consumer Survey.

That number is nearly a decade old now, and worth naming as such rather than pretending it's fresher than it is, but nothing about how these documents get signed has meaningfully changed since, and it's unlikely the real figure today is much different. This chapter isn't about becoming the kind of person who reads every word of every document. Almost nobody

does, and that's not really the goal. It's about getting the handful of things that actually matter out of twelve dense pages in the time you actually have.

It's about getting the handful of things that actually matter out of twelve dense pages in the time you actually have.

17.1 What Marisol could have done in the twenty-four hours she had

She didn't, that first time, and the lease turned out fine. But the method worth having ready for the next one: photograph or paste the actual document, or as much of it as you can get out of the landlord digitally, into an AI chat tool and ask, plainly, "This is a lease I'm considering signing. In plain English, what are the five most important things I should understand before I sign, especially anything unusual or worth asking the landlord about?" A genuinely useful answer flags the ordinary things (rent, deposit, notice period) fast, and spends its real attention on whatever's actually unusual: an early-termination penalty stiffer than standard, a maintenance responsibility quietly shifted onto the tenant, a clause about subletting that matters if life changes in the next year. That's the twelve pages compressed into the two minutes an exhausted Tuesday evening can actually spare.

17.2 Where this absolutely is not legal advice, said as plainly as chapter seven says it about money

A plain-English summary of a lease is not the same as a lawyer reviewing it, and for anything with real stakes, a lease you're unsure about, a contract with a business relationship attached, a legal document tied to a dispute already underway, that summary is where you get oriented before talking to a real person whose job this actually is, not where the process ends. Many cities and counties have free or low-cost tenant legal aid specifically for exactly this kind of question, worth a search alongside, not instead of, the plain-English pass.

17.3 Linda's version: the timeshare pitch

Linda and Hal sat through a ninety-minute timeshare presentation on a trip, mostly for the free breakfast the invitation promised, and left with a stack of paperwork and a salesperson's number, and a nagging feeling that the numbers they'd been shown didn't quite add up the way the pitch made them sound. That night, back at the hotel, Linda photographed the contract's key pages and asked: "This is a timeshare contract we're considering. In plain English, what does this actually commit us to financially over time, and what should we be skeptical of based on how these contracts commonly work?" The answer walked through the maintenance fees that would compound over decades, a detail the presentation had breezed past in one sentence, and named the general pattern of these contracts being harder to exit than they are to enter, a pattern worth researching further before signing anything. Linda and Hal didn't sign. They'd have been fine either way, financially, it wasn't a huge sum. What they got was clarity in an hour that would have otherwise taken a lawyer's appointment they wouldn't have booked before the cooling-off period expired.

17.4 A second pass, once the lease is already signed

The fine print doesn't stop mattering after signing day, and it's worth naming the second, quieter moment this method applies: a notice from the landlord months later, a rent increase, a policy change about parking or pets, framed as if it's simply how things are now. Marisol got exactly this kind of notice eight months into her lease, a new fee for something the original lease hadn't mentioned. The same plain-English pass, this time comparing the new notice against her original signed lease, confirmed the fee genuinely wasn't in the document she'd agreed to, giving her the specific, confident footing to question it in writing rather than simply assuming a landlord's new notice was automatically binding just because it arrived on official-looking letterhead.

17.5 Try this: the five-things prompt

For any document you’re about to sign that’s longer than a page and denser than plain English, try: “This is a [lease/contract/agreement] I’m considering. In plain English, what are the five most important things I should understand, especially anything unusual, before I sign?” Use the answer to decide what’s actually worth a closer read, or a real question to the other party, or a genuine lawyer’s five minutes, rather than trying to parse all twelve pages cold, under a deadline, at the end of a long day.

#	Before I sign this, I need to understand...
1	
2	
3	
4	
5	

FIGURE 17.1. *A blank worksheet for the five-things prompt. Fill it in after you get the plain-English answer back, before you sign anything, and circle whichever one is unusual enough to ask about.*

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- Signing without reading closely is the near-universal default, not a personal failing. The goal isn't becoming someone who reads every word, it's getting the handful of things that actually matter out of a dense document fast.
- A plain-English summary flags the unusual clauses a skim misses: early-termination penalties, shifted responsibilities, anything that departs from what's standard.
- This is not legal advice and doesn't replace one for anything with real stakes. It's where you get oriented before a real conversation with a lawyer or a tenant aid office, not where the process ends.
- The five-things prompt works on any document: a lease, a time-share pitch, a service contract, anything denser than plain English and longer than you have patience for at the end of a long day.

17.6 Where this goes next

Chapter eighteen steps back from the emotionally loaded tasks for a chapter and takes on something purely mechanical: the small tech problems, a printer that won't connect, an app that keeps crashing, that have nothing to do with AI and everything to do with the same plain-question habit fixing them anyway.

CHAPTER 18

Small Tech Problems That Aren't Really About AI

The printer had worked fine for two years and then, on the one morning Linda needed to print boarding passes before an early flight, it simply stopped talking to her laptop. No error message worth reading, just a blinking light and a print queue that sat there doing nothing. This is the kind of problem this whole book has been quietly sidestepping: not a letter, not a trip, not a scary appointment, just an ordinary piece of technology being ordinarily uncooperative at the worst possible moment, and it's worth its own short chapter precisely because it's the kind of thing that can make someone feel like a failure at "technology" in general, when it's really just one specific, fixable annoyance.

Linda typed into the same chat window she'd been using for four months by then: "My printer, a Canon Pixma, was working fine yesterday and now won't print from my laptop, a Windows computer. The printer's light is blinking amber and nothing happens when I try to print. What's the most likely cause and what should I try first?" The answer walked her through the two most common causes in order, a paused print queue and a low ink cartridge triggering a warning light, and the specific steps to check each one. It was the ink. Ninety seconds after she asked, she knew exactly what was wrong and exactly what to do about it, instead of the alternative, unplugging things at random and hoping, which is how most people, including Linda before this book, actually approach a stuck printer.

18.1 Why this belongs in a book about AI, of all things

There's a real irony worth naming: the same intimidation this book opened with, chapter one's fear that "not a tech person" is a fixed trait, shows up hardest exactly here, at the printer, the Wi-Fi router, the app that keeps crashing. These moments feel like proof of the thing you were afraid of. They're not. They're the single most common, most universally shared kind of tech frustration there is, and an AI tool is arguably better suited to this exact category of problem than almost anything else in this book, because troubleshooting is pattern-matching against thousands of nearly identical problems other people have already had and already solved.

*These moments feel like proof of the thing you were afraid of.
They're not.*

18.2 The habit that works almost every time

Describe exactly what you were doing right before it broke, exactly what happens now (an error message, word for word if there is one, or a plain description if there isn't), and what device and app you're using. "My Wi-Fi stopped working" gets a generic answer. "My internet was fine yesterday, and this morning my phone shows connected to Wi-Fi but nothing loads, while my laptop on the same network works fine" gets a specific, useful answer, because it narrows the actual cause fast: the problem is the phone, not the router, and that single detail changes everything about what to try first.

18.3 Marisol's version: the app that wouldn't stop crashing

The banking app Marisol used for years started closing itself the instant she opened it, every single time, right after an update she hadn't asked for and didn't remember agreeing to. She typed: "My banking app crashes immediately every time I open it, started right after the app updated itself

yesterday, on an Android phone. What should I try first?” The answer suggested the two most common fixes for exactly this pattern, clearing the app’s stored data and, if that failed, uninstalling and reinstalling it, in that order, cheapest and least disruptive first. Clearing the stored data fixed it in under a minute, instead of the hour she’d half-expected to lose calling her bank’s support line and sitting on hold.

18.4 Where this stops being enough, and what to do then

Some tech problems are genuinely bigger than a chat window can fix: actual hardware failure, an account security issue, anything involving a real financial loss already in progress. If a suggested fix doesn’t work after one or two reasonable tries, or if anything about the situation smells like the scam pattern chapter nine described, urgency, a request for a password or a code, stop and call the actual company or a person you trust, not a number the problem itself suggested. This chapter’s method is for the ordinary, everyday glitch, not a stand-in for real technical support when something’s genuinely broken.

18.5 The router reset nobody explains well

Wi-Fi problems deserve one specific extra word, because the advice for them is usually reduced to “turn it off and on again” without ever explaining why that works or when it doesn’t. A router and a modem are often two separate boxes even when they look like one, and the actual fix usually needs both power-cycled in the right order, modem first, wait a full minute, then the router, not both at once. “My internet is down. I have a separate modem and router, or one combined box (whichever is true for you). Walk me through the correct way to restart them and how long to wait between steps” gets a more useful answer than the vague advice everyone’s heard a hundred times and half of them apply wrong, unplugging both at once and wondering why it didn’t help.

18.6 Try this: the exact-symptom prompt

Next time something ordinary breaks, resist the urge to just restart everything and hope. Instead: “My [device/app] was working fine until [what changed or when it started]. Now [exactly what happens, word for word if there’s an error message]. What’s the most likely cause and what should I try first?” Specific symptoms get specific, useful answers, the exact same lesson as chapter two, aimed at a stuck printer instead of a dinner plan.

	What changed	Exact symptom	What fixed it
Linda’s printer	Nothing, until that morning	Blinking amber light, nothing printed	Checked the ink; it was low
Marisol’s banking app	The app updated itself	Crashed immediately on open	Cleared the app’s stored data

FIGURE 18.1. *Two ordinary glitches, run through the exact-symptom prompt’s own structure: what changed, what exactly happened, and the cheapest fix that actually worked.*

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- A stuck printer, a crashing app, or dead Wi-Fi isn't proof you're "not a tech person." It's the single most universal kind of tech frustration there is, and an AI tool is well suited to exactly this kind of pattern-matching.
- Describe the exact symptom, what changed right before it broke, and any error message word for word. Specific symptoms get specific, useful fixes.
- Try the cheapest, least disruptive fix first, the way both Linda's ink check and Marisol's cleared app data did, before anything more drastic.
- This is for ordinary glitches, not real technical support or a security issue already in progress. If something smells like chapter nine's scam pattern, stop and call a real, trusted number instead.

18.7 Where this goes next

Chapter nineteen is the lightest chapter in this book on purpose: something to try purely because you want to, not because a chore or a crisis demands it.

CHAPTER 19

Something Just for You

Every chapter so far has solved a problem: a letter, a bill, a broken printer, a scam to watch for. This one is different on purpose, and it's worth pausing on why before getting into it. Somewhere in a book full of tasks and chores and things to fix, it's easy to lose the fact that the exact same habits work just as well pointed at something that isn't a problem at all, just a thing you'd genuinely enjoy learning, with nobody depending on the outcome but you.

Linda had wanted to learn watercolor painting for years, in the vague, someday way people want things they've never quite given themselves permission to start. She didn't know where to begin, didn't want to sign up for a class full of strangers before she knew if she'd even like it, and didn't know the first thing about what supplies she actually needed versus what a store would try to sell her. She typed: "I've never painted before and want to try watercolor just for fun, no pressure to be good at it. What's the minimum I actually need to get started, and can you walk me through one simple, forgiving first painting to try this weekend?"

What came back wasn't a lecture. It was a short supply list, cheaper than she'd expected, and a genuinely patient, step-by-step walk through a simple painting of overlapping leaves, forgiving of a wobbly hand because watercolor's own unpredictability is part of the medium, not a flaw in a beginner's technique. She painted badly, by any real standard, on a Saturday afternoon at her own kitchen table. She also had more fun than she'd expected, and painted a second one the following weekend without being asked to.

Give yourself permission for it to be bad. That's most of what stopped you before.

19.1 Why a patient AI tutor is a genuinely good match for this

Chapter five's tutoring approach for Diego's homework, ask questions, don't just hand over the answer, works just as well here, except now there's no test to fail and no assignment due Monday. An AI tool has infinite patience for a beginner's questions that would embarrass most people to ask a real teacher twice: what does this word mean, can you explain that step again, why did mine come out wrong when I did what you said. There's no class schedule to keep up with, no cost per session, no one else's timeline but your own. For a genuine beginner, especially one who's spent years believing they'd "always meant to" learn something and never started, that combination removes nearly every practical excuse standing between someone and a Saturday afternoon.

19.2 Marisol's version: fifteen minutes at a time

Marisol had always wanted to learn Spanish properly, beyond the household phrases she'd absorbed from her own mother growing up, but never had ninety unbroken minutes for a class between two jobs and two kids. She used an AI tool differently than Linda did, not one big project but short, spoken five-minute conversations most evenings, practicing ordinary exchanges, ordering coffee, describing her day, in a low-stakes setting where a wrong verb conjugation cost her nothing and got corrected gently, not in front of anyone. Six months of five-minute evenings added up to something a single ninety-minute weekly class, the kind she never had time for, never would have.

19.3 The one honest limit worth naming

This isn't a replacement for a real class, a real teacher, or real other people if what you actually want from a hobby is the community around it, not just the skill itself. Watercolor painting has clubs and classes full of people who'd become real friends over shared frustration with wet paper; language learning has conversation partners who correct you with warmth a chat window can't quite offer back. If connection is part of what you're after, this is a good, patient on-ramp to get comfortable before walking into a room of strangers already knowing the basics, not a permanent substitute for the room.

19.4 When the hobby is physical, adjust accordingly

Not everything worth learning happens on a screen or a page, and it's worth saying plainly how this adjusts for something like gardening, woodworking, or learning an instrument, where the actual practice happens with your hands, away from any device. Linda's second attempt, months after the watercolor afternoon, was learning to keep houseplants alive, a skill she'd always assumed she simply lacked, having killed a memorable succession of them over the years. The chat window's role here was narrower and more useful for it: diagnosing what had likely gone wrong with past plants from her description of the symptoms, yellowing leaves, a particular watering pattern, and suggesting one forgiving, hard-to-kill plant to start with instead of a whole indoor jungle at once. The actual learning, the watering, the noticing, the patience, happened entirely away from the screen, the way it should for anything genuinely physical. The tool's job was orientation at the start, not company throughout.

19.5 Try this: pick one thing you've always meant to

Something you've said "I'd love to learn that someday" about, at some point, to someone, and never started. Type: "I've never [tried this] before and want to learn just for fun, no pressure. What's the minimum I need to get started, and walk me through one simple first attempt I could try this

week.” Give yourself permission for it to be bad. That’s most of what stopped you before.

Something I've	The minimum to	One small first at-
always wanted	get started	tempt this week
to try		

FIGURE 19.1. *A blank worksheet for the try-this prompt. Name the thing, find the minimum you actually need, then pick one attempt small enough to actually fit this week.*

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- The habits in this book work just as well on something you want purely for yourself as they do on a chore or a crisis. Don’t let the rest of this book’s problem-solving crowd that out.
- An AI tool’s patience for beginner questions, asked and re-asked without embarrassment, removes a real barrier that stops a lot of people before they start.
- Short, frequent practice, Marisol’s five-minute evenings, can add up to more than a single class you never had time for.
- This is a good on-ramp, not a replacement for real people and real community if connection is part of what you’re actually after.

19.6 Where this goes next

Two more ordinary tasks are still ahead, making sense of Medicare and insurance open enrollment, and pulling off a big family gathering without the month before it disappearing into logistics, before this book reaches the chapter it's been building toward all along: what it actually looks like to become the person your own family calls.

CHAPTER 20

Making Sense of Medicare and Insurance Choices

The envelope arrived in October the way it does every year, thick with a plan comparison booklet Linda always meant to read carefully and never quite did. Open enrollment, the annual window to change Medicare plans, closes in early December, and every year Linda did the same thing: skimmed the first page, felt the specific fog settle in that comes from words like “Medicare Advantage” and “Part D” and “supplement,” and kept the plan she already had, not because she’d checked it was still the best fit, but because checking felt like homework nobody had graded her on in forty years.

This year, with two months of a new habit behind her, she tried something different. She typed: “I’m 68, on Medicare, currently have [her actual plan type]. My main health needs are [she listed them honestly: a blood pressure medication, an annual checkup, Hal’s more frequent visits]. In plain English, what’s the actual difference between Medicare Advantage and Original Medicare with a supplement, and what questions should I be asking myself to figure out if my current plan still makes sense?”

KEY INSIGHT

A 2025 survey of more than 1,500 Medicare beneficiaries found 75 percent say choosing a Medicare plan is confusing, and roughly a third don't have a clear understanding of how the major plan types actually differ from each other. Linda's yearly fog isn't a personal failing. It's the documented, near-universal experience of the system itself.

Source: eHealth, 2025 Medicare survey.

20.1 What the answer actually did, and didn't do

The explanation reframed the difference in terms Linda could actually hold onto: Original Medicare with a supplement generally means more flexibility in which doctors you see, often at a higher monthly premium, while Medicare Advantage often costs less monthly but usually means staying within a specific network and needing more approvals for certain care. It didn't tell her which one to pick, and it said so directly, because that decision depends on details specific to her real health situation, her actual doctors, and numbers on her actual current plan documents that only she, or a licensed Medicare counselor, could properly weigh.

What it gave her instead was the same thing chapter six's appointment-prep habit gave her for Hal's scan: not an answer, a sharper set of questions to bring somewhere that could actually answer them. She used the state's free Medicare counseling service, called SHIP in most states, State Health Insurance Assistance Program, a real person whose entire job is exactly this conversation, and had, for the first time in years, a genuinely informed conversation instead of a confused skim followed by doing nothing.

The actual decision belongs with a free, licensed counselor (SHIP, or your plan's own enrollment help line) or a trusted family member who can look at your actual current numbers, not a chat window working from a general description.

20.2 Why this is not the place to just trust an answer and move on

Said as plainly as chapter six said it about a diagnosis: an AI tool does not know your specific plan's actual current costs, doesn't have access to which doctors are in which network this year, networks and costs change annually, and should never be the thing that actually picks your coverage. What it's good for is exactly what it did for Linda: turning intimidating jargon into plain language and turning "I don't know what to ask" into a real list of questions. The actual decision belongs with a free, licensed counselor (SHIP, or your plan's own enrollment help line) or a trusted family member who can look at your actual current numbers, not a chat window working from a general description.

20.3 Marisol's version: a younger, different kind of insurance confusion

Marisol's confusion wasn't Medicare, it was her employer's open enrollment, the same kind of jargon wall from chapter seven's insurance example, but this time comparing three plans instead of two, with a health savings account option thrown in that she genuinely didn't understand at all. "What's an HSA, in plain English, and how is it different from just having a regular insurance plan?" got her further in five minutes than the dense benefits packet had gotten her in a week of avoiding it. She still made the final call herself, based on her own real medical needs and her own real budget, the same non-negotiable line every chapter in this book draws around a decision this personal.

20.4 Try this: the plan-comparison prompt

"I'm comparing [insurance/Medicare plan options]. My situation is [honest specifics: age, health needs, current plan]. In plain English, what's the real difference between these options, and what questions should I bring to [a counselor / HR / the plan's help line] to actually decide?" Bring the questions somewhere a real person can answer them with your actual numbers in front of them.

Option	What it actually means
Original Medicare + supplement	More flexibility in which doctors you see; usually a higher monthly premium
Medicare Advantage	Often costs less monthly; usually a specific network, with more approvals needed for certain care

FIGURE 20.1. *The two paths behind this chapter’s own question, decoded once in plain English. Which one fits you still depends on your actual doctors and numbers, not this table.*

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- Three out of four Medicare beneficiaries find plan selection confusing. The fog Linda felt every October is the documented norm, not a personal gap.
- An AI tool can translate the jargon and sharpen your questions. It cannot see your actual current plan’s costs or networks, and should never be the thing that picks your coverage.
- Free, licensed help exists specifically for this: SHIP counselors for Medicare, HR or a plan’s own enrollment line for employer insurance. Use the plain-English pass to arrive at that conversation prepared, not to skip it.
- The same habit works at any age, any kind of insurance: state your real situation honestly, ask for the plain-English difference, and bring the sharpened questions to someone who can see your actual numbers.

20.5 Where this goes next

Chapter twenty-one turns to something warmer and considerably less bureaucratic: pulling off a big family gathering, a holiday, a reunion, without the whole month before it disappearing into logistics.

CHAPTER 21

A Big Family Gathering

Thanksgiving landed at Linda and Hal's house that year, all of it: both kids' families, Rose and her husband, a cousin visiting from out of state, eleven people total, one of them the same vegetarian granddaughter from chapter two's dinner, two others with a shellfish allergy Linda always worried about cross-contaminating without meaning to. Eleven people is a different animal than chapter two's six-person Sunday dinner, not just bigger, but layered: a full day's schedule, a kitchen that only fits so many dishes cooking at once, seating that has to account for a toddler's high chair and a great-aunt who needs to sit somewhere she can hear.

Linda had hosted this exact meal a dozen times before and every single year found herself, the Tuesday before, staring at a legal pad covered in crossed-out lists that never quite came together into an actual plan. This year she tried the chapter thirteen weekly-reset habit, scaled up: "I'm hosting Thanksgiving for 11 people, including one vegetarian and two people with shellfish allergies. Help me build a full timeline for the day, what to cook when so everything's hot at the same time, and a shopping list organized by what needs to be bought fresh versus what can be bought ahead."

21.1 What actually came back, and what she still had to do herself

The timeline solved the exact problem that had always defeated her: working backward from a 3 p.m. meal to figure out what needed to go in the oven at what time, given that only one oven existed and several dishes wanted it simultaneously. It flagged the vegetarian main as something that could be fully prepped the day before, freeing up stovetop space on the day itself, a detail Linda had never thought to plan around on her own. The shopping list, split into “buy this week” and “buy the day before,” turned a single overwhelming Saturday grocery trip into two calmer ones.

What it couldn't do, and didn't try to: know that Rose likes her stuffing without sage, or that the cousin visiting from out of state was bringing her own dessert and didn't need to be planned around for that course, or that the toddler's high chair genuinely needed to go at the end near the kitchen, not in the middle of the table where Linda had put it three years running before finally admitting it didn't work. Those details lived in Linda's head, the way they always had, and no timeline written by anyone who's never met this specific family could have supplied them.

Those details lived in Linda's head, the way they always had, and no timeline written by anyone who's never met this specific family could have supplied them.

21.2 Marisol's version: a smaller gathering, the same underlying problem

Marisol's version was Diego's tenth birthday, a backyard party for twelve kids and their parents, a different scale of the same overwhelm: a guest list, a food plan that had to account for at least two food allergies among the kids, a schedule for games that needed to hold twelve ten-year-olds' attention for two hours without chaos taking over. She used the same shape of prompt Linda had: “I'm planning a birthday party for 12 ten-year-olds, backyard, two hours, budget around \$150 for food and activities. Two kids have peanut

allergies. Give me a simple food plan and a schedule of activities that'll actually hold their attention."

What helped most wasn't the food list, which was fairly obvious once written down. It was the activity schedule, specifically the advice to plan for shorter attention spans than felt intuitive, fifteen-minute blocks instead of the thirty she'd originally planned, with a flexible buffer activity ready if something finished early. That single adjustment, informed by nothing more sophisticated than a reasonable general sense of how ten-year-olds' attention actually works, saved the party from the exact lull she remembered from a birthday party the year before, when a game ran out of steam ten minutes early and dissolved into arguing.

21.3 The actual value here, stated plainly

Big gatherings are hard for a specific, nameable reason: too many moving pieces to hold in one head at once, not because any single piece is complicated. A timeline, a shopping list split by timing, an activity schedule with real time estimates, these are exactly the kind of externalized-memory tasks an AI tool does well, the same shape as chapter thirteen's weekly reset, just scaled up to a bigger, higher-stakes day. What still belongs entirely to you: knowing your own family, the seating that avoids an old argument, the dish someone specifically requested, the small human details no planning tool anywhere could ever have known to include.

Task	Time	Who's doing it

FIGURE 21.1. *A blank day-of timeline, built the same way Linda’s finally was: work backward from when you actually want the meal on the table, and write down who’s handling each piece before the Tuesday-before panic sets in.*

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- A big gathering overwhelms because of the number of moving pieces, not their individual complexity. A written timeline and a split shopping list solve exactly that kind of problem.
- Ask for a full timeline working backward from your actual event time, and a shopping list split by what needs to be bought fresh versus ahead.
- The specific, personal details, who sits where, who’s allergic to what, who’s bringing dessert, stay entirely yours. No tool has ever met your family.
- The same method scales up or down: a big holiday meal and a kid’s backyard party solve the same underlying problem at different sizes.

21.4 Where this goes next

A last handful of everyday tasks are still ahead: caring for a parent, the college and financial aid maze, keeping a family connected across more than one language, an anxious question about a sick pet, making sense of a pay-check, the conversation almost nobody starts about a will, a repair estimate you don’t know whether to trust, and planning for a sudden gap in income. After that, this book reaches the chapter it’s been building toward all along: what it actually looks like to become the person your own family calls.

CHAPTER 22

Caring for a Parent

Marisol's mother's doctor had recently added a fourth medication to a list that already ran to three, and Marisol had started keeping track on a sticky note stuck to her own refrigerator, two states away from where her mother actually lived, because there wasn't a better system and the stakes of getting it wrong felt too high to leave to memory alone. She wasn't a nurse. She wasn't trained for any of this. She was just the daughter who happened to live close enough to visit twice a month and far enough to worry the rest of the time about what she wasn't seeing.

KEY INSIGHT

63 million Americans, nearly one in four adults, provided unpaid care for an adult family member or friend in the past year, a number that's grown by 20 million in just the past decade. Marisol's sticky note isn't a sign she's disorganized. It's the ordinary toolkit of an enormous, largely invisible workforce that mostly improvises its own systems, because almost nobody hands new caregivers one.

Source: AARP and the National Alliance for Caregiving, "Caregiving in the US 2025."

22.1 What actually helped, and what stayed entirely hers

Marisol used the same appointment-prep habit from chapter six, scaled to an ongoing situation instead of a single visit: after each of her mother's appointments, she'd type up the doctor's notes and any new medication into a chat window and ask, "Here's an update on my mother's care: [she pasted the details]. In plain English, are there any common interactions or timing issues I should ask her regular doctor about, and help me build a simple daily medication schedule I can share with her." What came back wasn't medical advice about what her mother should take, it explicitly wasn't that, and Marisol knew not to treat it that way. It was a clearly organized schedule, morning and evening columns, and a specific, well-formed question to bring to her mother's actual doctor about two medications with a known common interaction worth asking about directly.

The schedule replaced the sticky note. The actual medical judgment, what her mother should take and when, stayed exactly where it belonged: with her mother's doctor and pharmacist, the only people with her mother's full chart in front of them.

She was just the daughter who happened to live close enough to visit twice a month and far enough to worry the rest of the time about what she wasn't seeing.

22.2 The line, drawn as firmly as chapter six drew it

An AI tool can help organize information you already have: a medication list, an appointment history, a shared calendar with siblings who live further away and want to help but don't know how. It cannot replace a doctor's judgment about your parent's specific health, and it should never be asked to weigh in on whether a symptom is serious enough to call someone about. When in doubt about anything urgent, call the doctor or, for anything that feels like an emergency, call emergency services, the same non-negotiable line chapter fourteen drew around a genuine crisis.

22.3 Linda's version: further along the same road

Linda had been the one managing Hal's father's care in his final years, before this book's own story begins, and what she wished she'd had back then was something closer to what Marisol has now: a plain-English way to understand a new diagnosis fast, at eleven at night, when a specialist's letter arrived full of terms nobody had explained. She uses it differently now, further along, mostly for the logistics: a shared document, built with an AI tool's help organizing scattered notes into one place, that she and her siblings all update after a parent's appointment, so nobody's flying blind and nobody has to be the single point of failure holding every detail in their own head alone.

22.4 Caregiving from a distance, specifically

A real slice of caregiving happens exactly the way Marisol's does, from another state, coordinated in fragments between two jobs and two kids, and it's worth naming what changes when you're not the one physically in the room. She built a running document, an AI tool's help organizing months of scattered texts, calls, and appointment notes into one chronological summary she could hand to a sibling visiting in person, or read from herself on a call with a new specialist who'd never met her before. "Here are my notes from the past three months of my mother's care, in whatever order I have them. Organize this into a clean timeline I can reference or share." turned a scattered pile of half-remembered details into something a doctor unfamiliar with the case could actually use in the first two minutes of an appointment, instead of Marisol trying to reconstruct months of history from memory, under time pressure, in a room she wasn't even in.

22.5 Try this: the caregiving organizer prompt

"I'm helping care for [family member]. Here's the current situation: [medications, appointments, or concerns, described honestly]. Help me organize this into a clear, shareable [schedule / summary / calendar] I can use myself and share with other family members helping out." Use the result to stay organized and to sharpen the questions you bring to the actual doctor. Never

let it replace that doctor’s judgment, and never treat a symptom question as anything but a reason to call a real person.

Medication	When taken	Note for the doctor

FIGURE 22.1. *A blank version of the schedule that replaced Marisol’s sticky note. Photocopy it, or copy the three columns into a shared document any sibling helping out can update after an appointment.*

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- Nearly one in four American adults provides unpaid care for a family member. If this feels overwhelming and improvised, that’s the ordinary experience of an enormous, largely invisible group, not a sign you’re doing it wrong.
- An AI tool is genuinely useful for organizing scattered information: medication schedules, appointment histories, a shared record other family members can see.
- It cannot replace a doctor’s medical judgment, and any symptom question belongs to a real doctor or, for anything urgent, emergency services, not a chat window.
- Sharing a clear, organized record with other family members helping out means no single person has to hold every detail alone.

22.6 Where this goes next

Chapter twenty-three turns to a different kind of family worry, the paperwork maze of college and financial aid, and the same plain-English approach applied to one of the most notoriously confusing forms a family ever fills out.

CHAPTER 23

The College and Financial Aid Maze

Marisol's fifteen-year-old had started talking about college the way teenagers do, in fragments, mentioning a school she'd heard of and then changing the subject before Marisol could ask a real question. Marisol knew, distantly, that financial aid existed and that a form called the FAFSA was involved, and knew almost nothing more specific than that, and felt the particular dread of a parent who wants to help with something that matters enormously and doesn't know where the actual starting line is.

KEY INSIGHT

A survey of more than 15,000 students, reported by NASFAA, found that roughly 30 percent of first-generation and low-income students said completing the FAFSA was difficult, a rate 10 to 15 percentage points higher than their peers, with confusing questions and trouble gathering tax information named as the biggest obstacles. That confusion isn't new, and it isn't a sign of a family being unprepared. It's a well-documented, common experience of the process itself, one that can mean real aid money going unclaimed simply because the form felt too daunting to finish.

Source: EAB survey reported by NASFAA (National Association of Student Financial Aid Administrators), "Difficulty, Lack of Support Cited as Biggest Obstacles for FAFSA Completion Among Low-Income Students," 2021.

23.1 What Marisol actually did, a year before she needed to

She didn't wait for the form itself to start. She typed: "My daughter is a sophomore in high school and we're starting to think about college and financial aid. In plain English, what's the actual timeline, what is the FAFSA, and what should we be doing now, a year and a half before she'd apply, versus what can wait?" The answer gave her something she hadn't had before: an actual order of operations, when the FAFSA typically opens, what a Student Aid Index roughly means for what a family might be expected to contribute, and the plain fact that grades and test scores matter for admission but the FAFSA itself is a separate process entirely, one she'd been quietly conflating with the admissions essay her daughter kept avoiding.

That single conversation didn't fill out anything or commit to anything. It turned a fog with no visible starting point into a rough calendar with real dates on it, eighteen months out, which is exactly the kind of overwhelm chapter thirteen's weekly-reset habit was built to solve, aimed here at a much bigger and more consequential list.

That's not a decision an AI tool made. It's a decision Marisol and her daughter could only make once the real numbers were finally visible side by side.

23.2 Where the line sits, and it's a firm one

An AI tool can explain terms, walk through the general order of the process, and help draft the honest, plain-language parts of an application, a description of an extracurricular activity, a first pass at brainstorming essay topics before the writing itself becomes entirely the student's own. It cannot and should not fill out the actual FAFSA form with real financial information typed into a chat window, both because that's exactly the kind of sensitive financial data chapter ten said to keep out of these tools, and because the form itself has to be filed on the official federal site, not anywhere

else. And it absolutely should not write a college essay a student then submits as their own unaided work, for the same honesty reason chapter sixteen drew around a résumé: an essay claiming to be a student's authentic voice has to actually be their authentic voice.

23.3 Linda's version: a grandmother's version of the same maze

Linda's granddaughter, a year further along than Marisol's daughter, was drafting her personal statement and stuck the way chapter five's essay-writing scene described: not lacking ideas, lacking a way into the blank page. Linda, remembering the tutoring-question method from chapter five, suggested the same approach here: ask the tool to pose questions about the granddaughter's own experience rather than draft anything, and let her find her own argument through answering them. It worked the same way it had for the history essay: the words on the final page were entirely the granddaughter's, found through a conversation that helped her see her own material more clearly, not supplied by anyone else.

23.4 Comparing offers, once they actually arrive

Months later, when acceptance and aid letters finally arrived, Marisol faced a different kind of overwhelm: three schools, three completely differently formatted financial aid packages, each using its own shorthand for grants versus loans versus work-study, none of them presented in a way that made an honest side-by-side comparison easy. "Here are the financial aid offers from three schools: [she listed the actual figures from each]. Help me build a simple comparison of the real, out-of-pocket cost per year at each one, separating grants and scholarships that don't need repaying from loans that do." That single comparison did something the schools' own paperwork seemed almost designed to obscure: it showed plainly that the school with the most impressive-looking total aid number actually cost more out of pocket per year than a second option, once the loan portion was separated out from the grant portion. That's not a decision an AI tool made. It's a decision Marisol and her daughter could only make once the real numbers were finally visible side by side.

Aid type	What it actually is	Do you pay it back?
Grant or scholarship	Money awarded based on need or merit	No
Work-study	A part-time job the aid package funds	You earn it by working
Loan	Money borrowed to cover the rest	Yes, with interest

FIGURE 23.1. *The three categories every aid letter mixes together under its own shorthand. Separate them out first, and the real cost per year usually looks different from the total number at the top of the page.*

23.5 Try this: the process-orientation prompt

“We’re starting to think about college and financial aid for [student’s grade level]. In plain English, what’s the realistic timeline, what do the major terms mean, and what should we actually be doing now versus later?” Use it to build a calendar and understand the vocabulary. File the actual forms on the official government site, and keep any essay entirely the student’s own voice, found through questions, not handed to them finished.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- Roughly four in ten families find the FAFSA process genuinely confusing enough to be a real barrier. That confusion is common, not a sign of a family being behind or unprepared.
- An AI tool is genuinely useful for building a realistic timeline and translating unfamiliar terms, well before the actual forms are due.
- Never type real financial details into a chat tool to fill out an official aid form. File the real form on the official government site.
- A college essay has to stay the student's own authentic voice. The tutoring method from chapter five, questions instead of answers, applies here at real stakes.

23.6 Where this goes next

Chapter twenty-four turns to a different kind of family complexity: what this book's method looks like in a household where more than one language is spoken, and where translation itself is part of the everyday task.

CHAPTER 24

When Your Family Speaks More Than One Language

Marisol grew up translating for her mother, the way a lot of kids in bilingual households do without anyone officially assigning them the job: a letter from a school, a conversation with a pharmacist, a form at the DMV, all quietly routed through whichever child in the family had gotten furthest in English. She's an adult now, doing the same work for her mother in a different form, except now there's a tool that can help carry some of that load, and it took her a while to trust it with something this personal.

KEY INSIGHT

More than 22 percent of people in the United States, over one in five, speak a language other than English at home, and Spanish is by far the most common of those languages, spoken by roughly 42 million people. Marisol's household isn't an edge case this book almost forgot to mention. It's a genuinely common American household, and the tasks in every previous chapter run through it in exactly the layered way this chapter describes.

Source: U.S. Census Bureau, American Community Survey, Language Use in the United States.

24.1 What Marisol actually uses it for

Not everything, and knowing the difference mattered from the start. She uses it to translate the plain-English explanations from earlier chapters, the insurance letter from chapter one's whole opening story, the lease from chapter seventeen, back into Spanish for her mother, so her mother gets the same clarity Marisol gets, not a garbled, secondhand version relayed under time pressure on the phone. "Translate this explanation into natural, conversational Spanish, the way you'd actually explain it to someone, not a stiff, literal translation" produces something her mother can actually read and understand, rather than the word-for-word translations that sometimes technically parse and never actually sound like anything a person would say.

A mistranslated word in a casual text message costs almost nothing.

24.2 Where translation is genuinely useful, and where it isn't enough

Everyday, lower-stakes communication is where this shines: a text to a relative, understanding a menu, a rough first pass at a letter that needs a native speaker's polish before it goes anywhere important. For anything with real legal or medical weight, an immigration document, a court notice, a serious diagnosis explained by a doctor, a machine translation is a starting point for understanding, never the final word, the same not-a-replacement line this book has drawn everywhere else. Many hospitals and courts have professional human interpreters specifically because the stakes of a mistranslated medical or legal term are too high for anything less, and it's worth asking for one directly rather than assuming a family member, or a chat tool, should carry that weight instead.

If you ask for...	What you actually get
A literal, word-for-word translation	Something that technically parses and doesn't sound like anything a person would actually say
Natural, conversational wording, the way you'd explain it to someone	Something your family member can actually read and understand, not a garbled, secondhand version

FIGURE 24.1. *The one phrase that changes the whole result: ask for natural, conversational wording instead of a literal translation, and it actually sounds like something a person would say.*

24.3 Linda’s version: the other direction

Linda’s daughter-in-law’s parents speak mostly Mandarin, and family gatherings had always involved a certain amount of polite nodding across a language gap nobody quite knew how to close warmly. Linda started using a translation app during visits, nothing dramatic, just enough to ask a real question directly, “What was your own wedding like?”, instead of routing everything through her son the way they always had before. It didn’t erase the language gap. It gave her a few more real, direct exchanges per visit than she’d had in years of polite nodding, and that alone changed something about how those visits felt.

24.4 Official documents deserve extra caution, not less

The everyday translation habit this chapter describes gets riskier exactly where the stakes go up, and it’s worth naming the specific documents that deserve more caution, not less: anything involving immigration status,

a court filing, or an official government form. A mistranslated word in a casual text message costs almost nothing. The same kind of small, plausible-sounding error in an immigration document can cost real time, money, or worse, and these are precisely the documents where a professional, certified translator or a nonprofit immigration legal aid organization is worth seeking out directly, not approximated by any tool, however good the everyday translations have been so far.

24.5 The dignity question, worth naming directly

There's a real risk worth naming honestly: leaning on translation as a crutch that lets a family avoid ever actually learning each other's language, or worse, letting it replace a relationship that used to require real effort to bridge. That's a genuine tension this chapter can't fully resolve, and it's worth each family deciding for itself where the line sits between a helpful tool and an avoidance of the harder, slower, more rewarding work of actually learning to talk to each other. What this chapter can say plainly is that translation help used to have real conversations, more of them, more directly, is a net gain over the alternative of fewer conversations routed entirely through whoever happens to be bilingual in the room that day.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- More than one in five people in the U.S. live in a household where a language other than English is spoken. This is an ordinary American experience, not an exception this book almost overlooked.
- Ask for natural, conversational translation, not literal, word-for-word phrasing. The difference is often the whole difference in whether it actually sounds like something a person would say.
- For anything with real legal or medical weight, treat a machine translation as a starting point, and ask for a professional human interpreter, which many hospitals and courts provide directly.
- Used well, translation help means more direct conversations across a language gap, not fewer. Used as a total substitute for ever learning each other's language, it can become its own kind of distance.

24.6 Where this goes next

Chapter twenty-five turns to a smaller, more universal worry: a sick or aging pet, and the specific anxiety of understanding what a vet just told you.

CHAPTER 25

Pet Care Questions

The family dog, a fourteen-year-old terrier mix named Biscuit, had started drinking water like it was his job, and Linda noticed it for a week before mentioning it to anyone, half-hoping it would just stop on its own. When she finally looked it up on her own, late one night, the search results ranged from “probably nothing” to phrases frightening enough that she closed the browser tab and decided to just wait for the vet appointment already booked for the following week, a full seven days of quiet worry she hadn’t needed to carry alone.

KEY INSIGHT

A recent Gallup poll found that 52 percent of U.S. pet owners have skipped or delayed a veterinary visit, most commonly because of cost or because they weren’t sure the symptom was serious enough to warrant an appointment. The uncertainty Linda felt with Biscuit, worth a vet visit or not, is close to the median pet-owner experience, not a sign of an inattentive owner.

Source: Gallup, “52% of U.S. Pet Owners Skipped or Declined Veterinary Care.”

25.1 What actually would have helped, and what wouldn't have

An AI tool can't diagnose Biscuit any more than it could diagnose Hal back in chapter six, and it's worth saying that as firmly here as anywhere else in this book. What it could have done, and what Linda used for the next worry a few months later, is exactly the appointment-prep pattern from chapter six, aimed at a pet instead of a person: "My 14-year-old dog has been drinking noticeably more water for about a week, otherwise seems normal, eating fine, same energy. I have a vet appointment in three days. Is this the kind of symptom that's worth an earlier appointment, and what questions should I make sure to ask?" The answer didn't diagnose anything. It correctly flagged increased thirst as a symptom worth not waiting on if it continued, alongside several sharp, specific questions to bring to the vet, which turned out to matter: it was an early, very manageable kidney issue, caught meaningfully earlier because Linda called and moved the appointment up two days instead of waiting out the full week in quiet worry.

The answer didn't diagnose anything.

25.2 The line, drawn exactly where chapter six drew it for Hal

Never ask an AI tool what's wrong with your pet and treat the answer as a diagnosis. Use it to understand a symptom in plain English, to gauge roughly how urgent something might be, and to build a sharp list of questions for the actual veterinarian, who has examined the actual animal and can run actual tests. For anything that seems like it could be a real emergency, sudden collapse, difficulty breathing, suspected poisoning, call an emergency vet line immediately, the same call-first instinct chapter fourteen insists on for a person.

25.3 Marisol's version: the cost conversation nobody wants to have

Diego's cat needed a dental procedure the vet estimated at several hundred dollars, a real number against a budget that didn't have much give in it. Marisol didn't know whether to ask about payment plans, whether pet insurance would have helped in hindsight, or whether there were lower-cost options worth asking about before committing. She typed: "My cat needs a dental procedure estimated at [amount]. In plain English, what questions should I ask the vet about cost, payment options, or lower-cost alternatives, without it sounding like I'm questioning their judgment?" The answer gave her language that did exactly what she'd been unsure how to do herself: ask plainly about cost without it feeling like an accusation, a genuinely common, human awkwardness this book has named in other rooms too, chapter seven's embarrassment about money, wearing a different coat here.

25.4 The insurance question, before you need it

Pet insurance is easier to think through calmly before an emergency than during one, and it's a genuinely confusing product: different plans cover different things, most exclude a condition your pet already has by the time you sign up, and the math only works out in your favor for some pets and not others. "I have a [age, breed if relevant] pet, generally healthy. In plain English, how does pet insurance typically work, what does it usually not cover, and what questions should I ask before deciding whether it makes sense for my situation?" is a calmer, cheaper way to think it through on an ordinary Tuesday than working it out for the first time in a vet's waiting room with a four-figure estimate already in hand.

25.5 Try this: the pet-symptom prompt

"My [pet, age, general health] has [symptom, how long, anything else notable]. I have/don't have a vet appointment [timeframe]. Is this the kind of thing worth an earlier appointment, and what questions should I bring?" For anything that reads as a possible emergency, skip the chat window and call an emergency vet line directly.

Symptom	How long	Other notes	Vet appointment

FIGURE 25.1. *A blank version of the pet-symptom prompt from this chapter. Fill it in the next time something seems off, and bring it to the vet whether or not you end up asking the tool anything first.*

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- More than half of pet owners have skipped or delayed a vet visit, usually over cost or uncertainty about whether a symptom is serious. That uncertainty is common, not a sign of neglect.
- An AI tool can’t diagnose your pet. It can help you gauge urgency in plain English and build sharp questions for the actual vet.
- For a possible emergency, call an emergency vet line immediately, the same firm rule this book applies to a human medical emergency.
- Asking plainly about cost and payment options is a normal, common question. A little help finding the right words removes the awkwardness of asking it.

25.6 Where this goes next

Chapter twenty-six turns to a document that shows up in nearly every mailbox and confuses nearly everyone who opens it: your own paycheck.

CHAPTER 26

Understanding Your Paycheck and Taxes

Marisol's promotion, the one that came through after chapter sixteen's rewritten résumé, brought a real raise and a new problem: a bigger tax refund than usual the following spring, which sounds like good news until you understand what it actually means, that too much had been withheld from every paycheck all year, an interest-free loan Marisol had unknowingly been giving the government instead of having that money in her own account when she needed it. She'd filled out a W-4 form once, years earlier, for her very first job, glanced at it for thirty seconds, and never touched it again.

KEY INSIGHT

In an H&R Block survey, only 46 percent of taxpayers said they felt prepared to update their own tax withholding without help, and 45 percent weren't sure what actually counts as a withholding allowance in the first place. That survey is several years old now, and there's no real reason to think the confusion has meaningfully eased since. Marisol's untouched W-4 isn't unusual. It's close to the default.

Source: H&R Block, December 2018 consumer survey on tax withholding.

26.1 What Marisol actually did

She typed: “I got a raise and my tax refund was unusually large this year, which I understand might mean too much is being withheld from my paycheck. In plain English, what does a W-4 form actually control, and what questions should I answer for myself before adjusting it?” The explanation walked through what withholding actually is, money set aside from each paycheck toward taxes you’ll owe, and why a big refund means you overpaid all year rather than something to celebrate, alongside the genuine tradeoff: less withheld means more money in each paycheck now, but a smaller refund or even a bill at tax time if it’s adjusted too far. It didn’t fill out her form or tell her the exact numbers to enter. It gave her the plain-English understanding she needed to actually make that decision herself, and a specific recommendation to use the IRS’s own free withholding estimator tool, which does the real calculation with her actual numbers, rather than guessing.

The plain-English pass didn’t replace their accountant, who they still saw once a year. It made that one annual meeting sharper, arriving with real questions instead of a vague, general worry about whether everything was fine.

26.2 Reading an actual pay stub, line by line

The same plain-English habit works on the pay stub itself, dense with abbreviations nobody explains: FICA, gross versus net, a line for a benefit deduction that’s easy to stop noticing entirely. “Here’s my pay stub, explain each line in plain English” turns a document most people stop actually reading after their first few paychecks back into something legible, worth doing at least once a year, especially after any raise, benefit change, or new deduction appears.

Term	What it actually means
Gross pay	What you earned before anything is taken out
Net pay	What actually lands in your account after deductions
FICA	The line for Social Security and Medicare taxes
W-4	The form that tells your employer how much to withhold from each paycheck

FIGURE 26.1. *Four lines almost every pay stub and W-4 form include, decoded once so you're not re-figuring them out from scratch every time one changes.*

26.3 The credit or deduction you didn't know to ask about

A second, related use worth naming: tax credits and deductions are numerous enough that most people only ever learn about the two or three that apply to their own situation, usually by accident. Marisol didn't know a Child and Dependent Care Credit existed until a coworker mentioned it offhand, well after a year she could have claimed it. "I'm a single parent with two kids, [rough income range], paying for after-school care. In plain English, what common tax credits or deductions might apply to a situation like mine, that I should ask a real tax preparer about?" isn't a substitute for a professional doing the actual filing, but it's a genuinely useful way to walk into that appointment with informed questions instead of hoping the preparer happens to ask the right ones.

26.4 Where this stops being enough

An AI tool can explain what a line on a pay stub generally means and walk through general tax concepts, but it doesn't know your complete financial picture, and for anything beyond a fairly ordinary paycheck, self-employment income, a complicated deduction, an actual dispute with the IRS, the honest next step is a real tax professional or the IRS's own free resources, not a chat window carrying the whole decision alone. The same line chapter seven drew around bigger financial decisions applies here at exactly the same weight.

26.5 Linda's version: a retirement-income puzzle

Linda and Hal's retirement income now came from several different sources, Social Security, a small pension, withdrawals from savings, each taxed a little differently, and the plain question Linda actually had was simple even though the system wasn't: was enough being withheld across all of it combined, or were they quietly heading toward an unpleasant surprise the following April. The plain-English pass didn't replace their accountant, who they still saw once a year. It made that one annual meeting sharper, arriving with real questions instead of a vague, general worry about whether everything was fine.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- Fewer than half of taxpayers feel prepared to manage their own withholding, and a large minority don't fully understand what a withholding allowance even is. Confusion here is closer to normal than exceptional.
- A big tax refund isn't free money. It usually means too much was withheld all year, an interest-free loan to the government instead of money in your own paycheck.
- Use the plain-English pass to understand your options, then use the IRS's own free withholding estimator, or a real tax professional, to actually decide the numbers.
- Reading your own pay stub once a year, line by line, catches errors and forgotten deductions a habit of never looking would miss entirely.

26.6 Where this goes next

Chapter twenty-seven turns to the conversation almost nobody starts on their own: wills, advance directives, and the paperwork that answers hard questions in advance instead of in a hospital hallway.

CHAPTER 27

Advance Planning and the Conversation Nobody Starts

Hal's cousin had a health scare that fall, nothing fatal in the end, but serious enough that for two frightening days his family didn't know who was authorized to make a medical decision on his behalf if it came to that, because he'd never gotten around to filling out the paperwork that would have answered the question in advance. Linda and Hal drove home from visiting him in the hospital mostly quiet, both privately doing the same math: their own will was years out of date, and neither of them had ever filled out an advance directive, the document that says what kind of care you'd want if you couldn't speak for yourself, at all.

KEY INSIGHT

A 2025 Caring.com survey found only 24 percent of Americans currently have a will, down from a third of respondents just three years earlier. Hal's cousin's unanswered question, and Linda and Hal's own outdated paperwork, aren't unusual lapses. They're the ordinary, majority experience of putting this off indefinitely, right up until a hospital hallway makes the cost of that suddenly, uncomfortably concrete.

Source: Caring.com, "2025 Wills and Estate Planning Study," conducted with YouGov.

27.1 What actually got them started

Not a lawyer's office, not yet. Linda typed: "We're in our late 60s, have an outdated will and no advance directive or healthcare power of attorney. In plain English, what's the actual difference between these documents, and what should we understand and decide on our own before we sit down with a lawyer, so that appointment isn't spent explaining basics to us?" The answer walked through what each document actually does, a will for after death, an advance directive and healthcare power of attorney for decisions while alive but unable to communicate, and named the honest, personal questions worth thinking through beforehand: who they'd each trust to make a medical decision, and roughly what kind of care they'd want or not want in a situation neither of them likes to picture.

That conversation, uncomfortable and important, happened between Linda and Hal themselves, at their own kitchen table, exactly where it belonged. What the plain-English pass did was make sure they arrived at the actual lawyer's office already understanding the vocabulary and already having had the hard conversation privately, rather than having it for the first time in front of a stranger billing by the hour.

That conversation, uncomfortable and important, happened between Linda and Hal themselves, at their own kitchen table, exactly where it belonged.

27.2 The line, drawn as firmly as chapter seventeen drew it around a lease

This is not legal advice, and a will or a healthcare directive drafted without a real lawyer's review can fail in ways that matter enormously precisely when a family can least afford a mistake. Use the plain-English pass to understand the vocabulary and have the personal conversation. Have an actual attorney draft or review the real documents. Many communities have free or low-cost legal aid clinics specifically for this, worth asking about directly if cost is the thing standing in the way.

27.3 Marisol's version: a harder conversation, at a younger age

Marisol was thirty-four, with two young kids and no will at all, the kind of thing that feels optional right up until you actually think through what would happen to Diego and his sister if something happened to her. She used the same plain-English approach to understand what a guardianship designation actually is, a specific, legal statement of who would raise her kids if she couldn't, and realized it was a conversation she needed to have with her own sister before any document could reflect it. The document came later, with a real attorney. The harder, more important conversation, who would actually raise her kids, happened first, at her kitchen table, because a plain-English explanation finally made clear that it was a decision only she and her sister could make, not something that could wait for someday.

27.4 The digital side nobody thinks to plan for

A newer wrinkle worth naming directly: photos, financial accounts, email, and years of messages now live in accounts that don't automatically pass to anyone the way a physical box of letters would. "In plain English, what's a digital estate plan, and what basic steps should I take to make sure someone I trust can access or close my important online accounts if something happens to me?" surfaced something Linda hadn't considered at all: most major services let you designate a legacy contact or beneficiary in advance, a five-minute setting most people never find because nobody thinks to look for it until it's too late to ask the account holder directly.

Document	What it actually does
Will	Says who gets what after you die
Advance directive	Says what care you want if you can't speak for yourself while alive
Healthcare power of attorney	Names who can make medical decisions for you if you can't
Guardianship designation	Names who would raise your kids if you couldn't

FIGURE 27.1. *Four documents this chapter untangles, decoded once so the actual attorney’s office is spent finishing them, not explaining them from scratch.*

27.5 Try this: the plain-English estate-planning prompt

“I’m [your situation: age, family structure, whether you have existing documents]. In plain English, what’s the difference between a will, a health-care directive, and [other relevant document], and what personal decisions should I think through before meeting with a lawyer?” Have the hard conversation with the people it actually involves first. Then get a real attorney, or a legal aid clinic, to make it official.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- Fewer than a quarter of Americans currently have a will. Putting this off is the ordinary experience, not a personal failing, right up until a real situation makes the cost suddenly visible.
- A plain-English pass is genuinely useful for understanding what each document actually does and for having the personal conversation it requires, with the people it actually involves.
- This is never a substitute for a real attorney. Use free or low-cost legal aid clinics if cost is the barrier standing between understanding and actually getting it done.
- The hardest part usually isn't the paperwork. It's the conversation the paperwork forces you to finally have, out loud, with the people it affects.

27.6 Where this goes next

Chapter twenty-eight turns to a smaller, more immediate kind of dread: standing in a repair shop, being handed an estimate you don't fully understand, and not knowing whether to trust it.

CHAPTER 28

When the Car Needs Real Repairs

The mechanic's estimate came to \$1,400, a list of parts and labor codes Marisol had no way to evaluate, for a noise her car had started making that she genuinely couldn't have described more precisely than "a clunking sound when I turn." She had no idea whether \$1,400 was fair, inflated, or even the right fix for the actual problem, and standing at the counter with a stranger waiting for her answer is not a good moment to start researching from scratch.

KEY INSIGHT

A 2023 AAA consumer survey found 77 percent of U.S. drivers distrust auto repair shops, most commonly over fear of unnecessary services recommended or being overcharged for real ones. That distrust isn't paranoia. It's the majority, documented experience of standing at exactly the counter Marisol stood at, without enough information to know if a number is fair.

Source: AAA, 2023 consumer survey on driver trust in auto repair shops.

28.1 What Marisol actually did, right there at the counter

She didn't sign anything immediately, and that alone is worth naming as the actual first move: asking for a written copy of the estimate to review, which any legitimate shop will provide without hesitation. From her car in the parking lot, she typed: "My mechanic gave me this estimate for a clunking noise when turning: [she listed the parts and labor from the actual paper]. In plain English, what do these items mean, does this combination make sense for the symptom I described, and is this price range reasonable for this kind of repair?" The answer translated the labor codes into plain descriptions, confirmed the general category of parts made sense for a turning-related clunk, a common wear part on that kind of repair, and gave her a rough sense of a typical price range for the same repair regionally, enough to walk back in and ask one specific, informed question rather than either blindly accepting or blindly refusing.

Knowing when a number is reasonable, not just when it isn't, is worth just as much as catching an inflated one, and it's the less dramatic half of this chapter that matters just as much as the more satisfying half.

28.2 What this does and doesn't replace

An AI tool has never looked at Marisol's actual car and can't diagnose the noise itself, the same limit chapter six drew around a symptom and chapter twenty-five drew around a sick pet. What it can do well is exactly what it did here: translate an estimate's jargon into plain language and give a rough sense of whether a price and a proposed fix are in a reasonable range, which turns an intimidating wall of unfamiliar terms into a short, specific list of real questions. For anything expensive or where trust is genuinely in doubt, a second opinion from another shop remains the gold standard this book has pointed to in every high-stakes chapter, chapter eleven's verified reviews, chapter seventeen's real lawyer, applied here to a mechanic instead.

28.3 Linda’s version: knowing when not to fight it

Hal’s truck needed a transmission repair that came in at nearly \$3,000, a number large enough that Linda’s instinct was suspicion first. The plain-English pass this time confirmed something less satisfying than a story about an overcharging mechanic: transmission repairs are genuinely expensive, the estimate was actually in line with typical costs for that specific repair, and the honest answer wasn’t “negotiate harder,” it was “get one more quote to confirm, then this is probably just what it costs.” Knowing when a number is reasonable, not just when it isn’t, is worth just as much as catching an inflated one, and it’s the less dramatic half of this chapter that matters just as much as the more satisfying half.

28.4 One more question worth adding: is this actually a recall

Before paying for any repair on a specific, known problem area, one extra question is worth the thirty seconds it takes: “Is [the specific issue] on a [year, make, model] ever the subject of a manufacturer recall?” Recalls get fixed free at a dealership, and a surprising number of drivers never think to check before paying out of pocket for a problem the manufacturer already owes them a free fix for. It won’t catch every case, and it’s worth confirming directly with a dealership rather than trusting the answer alone, but it takes thirty seconds to ask and has real money on the other side of a yes.

Line item	What it means	Matches symptom?

FIGURE 28.1. *A blank copy of the repair-estimate prompt, ready to fill in line by line the next time an estimate lands in your hands: what it says, what it means, and whether it actually matches the noise or the problem you brought the car in for.*

28.5 Try this: the repair-estimate prompt

“My mechanic gave me this estimate for [the symptom, described specifically]: [list the actual line items]. In plain English, what do these mean, does this fix match my symptom, and is this price reasonable?” Use the answer to ask one sharp, informed question back at the counter. For anything expensive or in doubt, get a second opinion from an actual second shop before committing.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- More than three-quarters of drivers distrust auto repair shops, mostly over fear of overcharging or unnecessary work. That wariness is the documented majority experience, not an overreaction.
- A plain-English pass on a written estimate turns an intimidating wall of jargon into specific, informed questions you can actually ask at the counter.
- This doesn’t replace a second opinion from a real shop for anything expensive or genuinely in doubt, the same gold standard this book applies everywhere the stakes are real.
- Sometimes the honest answer is that the number is simply what the repair costs. Confirming a fair price is worth just as much as catching an unfair one.

28.6 Where this goes next

One last hard scenario is worth walking through before this book closes: planning for a sudden or expected gap in income. After that, this book reaches

the chapter it's been building toward all along: what it actually looks like to become the person your own family calls.

CHAPTER 29

Planning for a Layoff or Income Gap

The email arrived at 4:50 on a Friday, the way these things so often do, a “restructuring” that included Marisol’s entire department, effective in two weeks. She sat in her car in the parking lot for twenty minutes before driving home, running a rough, frightening math in her head: two weeks of pay, a mortgage-sized rent, two kids, and a job search that chapter sixteen had taught her how to do well but hadn’t promised would be fast.

KEY INSIGHT

An Empower survey found 42 percent of workers said their current savings wouldn’t be enough to see them through if they lost their job tomorrow. Marisol’s twenty minutes of frightened math in a parking lot is close to the median experience of hearing that news, not a sign she’d managed her money badly.

Source: Empower, June 2025 survey on financial stress and job security.

29.1 What she did that first weekend

Not panic-apply to everything visible, which chapter sixteen had already taught her produces worse results than a smaller number of well-tailored applications. Instead, that Saturday morning, she typed: “I was just laid off, two weeks’ notice, two kids, [her rough monthly expenses]. In plain English,

help me build a bare-bones budget for the next three months assuming no income, and walk me through what unemployment benefits typically cover and how to apply in [her state].” The budget wasn’t complicated, it just organized numbers that had been swirling anxiously in her head into an actual plan: which bills were truly fixed, which had any flexibility, and a rough number for how many weeks her savings plus likely unemployment benefits would actually stretch. That number, worked out calmly on a Saturday morning instead of guessed at in a panic, turned out to be six weeks longer than her frightened parking-lot math had assumed, because she hadn’t been accounting for unemployment benefits at all.

That number, worked out calmly on a Saturday morning instead of guessed at in a panic, turned out to be six weeks longer than her frightened parking-lot math had assumed, because she hadn’t been accounting for unemployment benefits at all.

29.2 The line, and why it matters here specifically

An AI tool can explain how unemployment benefits generally work and help build a bare-bones budget from numbers you provide. It doesn’t know your state’s specific current benefit amount or exact eligibility rules, which change and vary by state, and the honest next step is always your state’s actual unemployment office, whose website and phone line exist specifically to answer these questions with real, current, binding numbers. Use the plain-English pass to understand the general shape of the process and arrive at that call informed, not to substitute for it.

29.3 What else the budget conversation surfaced

Beyond the bare-bones number, the same conversation helped Marisol think through questions she hadn’t known to ask herself: whether COBRA

health insurance continuation made sense for her family versus a market-place plan, a genuinely complicated comparison chapter twenty's insurance-literacy habit applied to directly, and which bills to call proactively about extending payment on, before they were late, rather than after. None of these were decisions the tool made for her. Each one was a question she hadn't known existed until a calm, organized conversation surfaced it, the same value chapter six's appointment-prep habit provides, aimed here at a financial crisis instead of a medical one.

29.4 The résumé and the budget, running side by side

Marisol's actual weeks after the layoff ran two tracks at once, the job search from chapter sixteen and the budget from this chapter, and it's worth naming that most real income gaps work this way rather than as two neatly separated phases. She kept both conversations going in parallel: a weekly check-in with herself, updating the budget as real numbers replaced estimates, unemployment payments that landed a little smaller than expected, one bill successfully deferred, alongside the ongoing work of tailoring applications to postings as they appeared. Neither track waited for the other to finish. The budget conversation gave her enough calm to focus on the job search without a constant background hum of financial panic drowning out the actual work of finding the next role.

29.5 Linda's version: further down the road, a different kind of gap

Linda and Hal's income gap wasn't a layoff, it was the stretch of months between Hal's retirement and his pension actually starting, a planned gap rather than a sudden one, but one that still benefited from the same bare-bones planning. Knowing the gap was coming months in advance meant Linda could ask the plain-English budgeting question calmly, well ahead of time, turning what could have been a stressful few months into a period they'd genuinely planned for and expected.

Category	Monthly amount
Fixed bills (rent, insurance, minimum payments)	_____
Flexible spending (groceries, discretionary)	_____
Expected unemployment benefit	_____
Savings on hand	_____

FIGURE 29.1. *The bare-bones three-month budget, blank and ready for your own numbers: what’s truly fixed, what has flexibility, and what unemployment and savings actually add up to before you need either.*

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- Four in ten workers say their savings wouldn’t carry them through a sudden job loss. The fear in that moment is close to universal, not a personal financial failing.
- A calm, organized budget conversation, built the same weekend as the bad news, often reveals more runway than frightened mental math assumes, especially once unemployment benefits are actually accounted for.
- An AI tool can explain the general shape of benefits and help build a budget. Your state’s actual unemployment office has the real, current numbers, and that call is not optional.
- The same calm-planning habit works for an expected income gap, a retirement transition, a planned leave, just as well as an unexpected one.

29.6 Where this goes next

The chapter this whole book has been building toward is next: what it actually looks like to become the person your own family calls.

CHAPTER 30

Teaching Someone Else

Linda's sister Rose called on a Tuesday, the way she does every couple of weeks, and somewhere in the middle of the usual catching-up she mentioned, almost apologetically, that her doctor's office had sent a confusing letter about a billing change and she didn't understand it and didn't want to bother anyone about it. Six months earlier, Linda would have said "oh, that sounds annoying" and moved on, because six months earlier Linda was the one avoiding a blank text box at her own kitchen table.

Instead she said, "Send me a picture of it. I'll walk you through what I do." Not "I'll figure it out for you." Walk you through. She talked Rose through pasting the letter's confusing sentence into a chat window and asking for a plain-English explanation, the exact habit from chapter one, and stayed on the phone while Rose typed her own version of the question, in her own words, and read her own answer back. Twenty minutes later Rose understood the letter, and something else had happened alongside that: Rose had done it herself, with Linda narrating rather than doing it for her, and the blank box that had intimidated her a week earlier didn't feel like a locked door anymore.

30.1 The actual shape of this chapter

This isn't a chapter about a new skill. Every skill in this book has already been covered. This is a chapter about a shift that happens naturally, usually without anyone planning it: at some point, a few real wins into using these

tools, you stop being the person who needed the fear talked down and start being the person someone else calls when they're stuck at their own kitchen table. Linda's granddaughter set up the app for her back in chapter one, then went back to college the next morning, and Linda spent a week alone with a blinking cursor before she found the first sentence. This chapter is about not leaving Rose alone with hers.

KEY INSIGHT

Among U.S. adults 65 and older, only 23 percent use AI chatbots, compared with 63 percent of adults under 50, a 40-point gap. Roughly three-quarters of adults 65 and older say they never use chatbots at all. That gap doesn't close itself. It closes one kitchen-table conversation at a time, the way most real technology adoption in a family always has.

Source: Pew Research Center, "How Americans' opinions and use of AI differ by age," June 2026.

That gap is this book's whole reason for existing, stated as a number instead of a story. Somebody has to be the one who sits down next to Rose, or Linda, or whoever the Rose is in your own family, and narrates instead of doing it for them. This chapter is about how to do that well, because "well" and "badly" produce very different outcomes from the exact same good intention.

You are now the person who can make that call.

30.2 The mistake that undoes all of it

The single most common way this goes wrong is the most well-meaning one: taking the phone or the keyboard and just doing it for them, because it's faster, because you can see they're struggling, because it's genuinely quicker to type the question yourself than to walk someone through typing it. It is faster. It's also exactly Linda's granddaughter's original mistake, six months earlier, the one that left Linda alone with a blank box for a week. Doing it for someone teaches them that the task is something only you can

do. Walking them through it teaches them the task is something they can do. Those produce completely different people six months later.

The fix is almost annoyingly simple: whoever has the problem holds the phone. You can look over their shoulder, suggest the words, catch a typo, but their thumbs do the typing. It takes longer in the moment. It’s the only version that actually transfers anything.

	Doing it for them	Walking them through it
Who holds the phone	You	Them
Who types	You	Them, while you suggest words
Speed, this time	Faster	Slower
What they can do alone next time	Nothing new	The same task, unprompted

FIGURE 30.1. *The one choice that decides whether teaching someone actually transfers anything.*

30.3 Marisol’s version: the same fix, aimed backward

Chapter nine’s script gave Marisol a way to talk to her mother about scams. What came after that first conversation surprised her: her mother, once the immediate fear of the scam call was addressed, got curious about the rest of it, what else this thing could actually help with. Marisol found herself doing with her own mother exactly what Linda did with Rose, minutes at a time on video calls, letting her mother hold her own phone and type her own words while Marisol narrated. Her mother’s first real, unprompted

use of it, weeks later and entirely on her own, was working out a substitution for an ingredient she didn't have for a recipe she'd made a hundred times without ever needing help before. Small. Also entirely hers, unprompted, and that's the actual measure of whether the teaching worked.

30.4 What to actually say the first time

If you're looking for a place to start with your own Rose, here's a version worth borrowing, close to what actually worked for both Linda and Marisol: "Show me something you've been wanting to ask or figure out, doesn't matter how small. Let's type it together, you hold the phone, I'll just help if you get stuck." Small and low-stakes on purpose, the same instinct as chapter three's advice to start with dinner, not a trip: the goal of a first lesson is one real win, not a comprehensive tour.

30.5 The quieter version of the same skill

Teaching someone doesn't only mean sitting down for a lesson. It also shows up as a habit worth keeping alive long after the first lesson is over: actually understanding each other, not just staying in touch. Linda's granddaughter texts in a language Linda mostly follows and occasionally doesn't at all, an abbreviation, an emoji used in a way that means something other than its obvious meaning. Linda used to just reply warmly and vaguely, the way you nod along at a party conversation you've lost the thread of. Now, instead of nodding along, she asks: "My teenage granddaughter texted me '[the actual phrase], no cap.' What does that mean in this context?" Two minutes, and one fewer small gap between them.

Marisol uses the same instinct in the other direction. Her own mother sends long, rambling voice messages instead of texts, a style Marisol doesn't always have five uninterrupted minutes to listen to properly. She started using her phone's own transcription feature to skim a quick text version first, catching anything urgent immediately, then going back to actually listen to the full message later when she had the time it deserved. And before video calls with her granddaughter, Linda started preparing one specific question, pulled from something Rose had mentioned in passing, instead of the same broad "so, what's new" that always got the same thin "nothing

much” back, the same lesson chapter two taught about talking to an AI tool, applied here to a grandchild instead.

None of this is about mediating a family relationship through a screen. It’s the opposite: fewer moments of nodding along without understanding, so the real conversation underneath actually happens.

30.6 The book’s actual last argument

Back near the start, this book opened by saying the hesitation at Linda’s kitchen table wasn’t really about the technology, it was a learned fear that everyone else already had the manual. That fear moves through families exactly like this: someone who’s never been shown assumes everyone else already knows, stays quiet about it, and the gap gets treated as a permanent fact about who they are instead of what it actually is, a temporary gap in exposure that one twenty-minute phone call closes. You are now the person who can make that call. That was always the actual point of everything before this page.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- Adults 65 and older use AI chatbots at roughly a third the rate of adults under 50. That gap closes one real conversation at a time, not on its own.
- The single most common teaching mistake is taking over and doing it for them. Whoever has the problem holds the phone and does the typing, every time, even when it’s slower.
- Start small and low-stakes, the same instinct as chapter three’s first trip-planning message: one real win beats a comprehensive tour.
- The same instinct that teaches someone a new skill keeps a relationship close afterward: a two-minute check on an unfamiliar phrase, one specific question instead of a broad one, is worth as much as the first lesson was.

30.7 Where this goes next

What's left is a different kind of reading than everything before it: two families followed through a full season of ordinary tasks using everything in this book at once, an honest look at what all of this actually saves you, the honest pushback and hard questions this book hasn't fully answered yet, and every template and exact prompt from every chapter, collected in one place to keep by the kitchen table.

CHAPTER 31

Two Families, One Season

Every chapter so far has isolated one task, on purpose, so the habit underneath it would be easy to see clearly. Real life doesn't arrive in isolated chapters. It arrives as a season, tasks overlapping and interrupting each other, some of it planned and some of it not, all of it happening to the same tired person at the same kitchen table. This chapter follows Linda's household and Marisol's household through one real autumn, September through December, using everything in this book more or less the way it actually gets used: unevenly, in fragments, between everything else going on.

31.1 September: Linda

The season opened with the mattress company still stonewalling the refund from chapter four, three weeks unresolved by the time September started. Linda's escalation letter, the firm-but-not-angry version she'd drafted back then, finally got a response the second week of September: a full refund, processed without further argument, closing a loop that had opened in July. The same week, her sister Rose called about the confusing medical billing letter that opened chapter thirty's earlier version of this story, and Linda walked her through pasting it into a chat window rather than reading it for her, twenty minutes on the phone that left Rose noticeably steadier by the end of the call.

Linda and Hal also started, tentatively, planning the downsizing move from chapter thirteen that same month, the room-by-room, week-by-week

schedule turning a shapeless dread into six specific Saturdays stretching from late September into November. The first of those Saturdays, the spare room, went fine. The second one didn't get touched at all, because Hal's cousin had a health scare that took over the weekend instead, and the schedule simply absorbed the miss and picked back up the following week rather than collapsing over it, which is closer to how real plans actually survive than the tidy six-Saturday version might have suggested on paper.

31.2 September: Marisol

Marisol's September opened with Diego's fractions homework, the same tutoring-question method from chapter five, now a settled Tuesday-and-Thursday routine rather than a novelty. It also opened with the lease renewal on her apartment landing on her desk with a rent increase eleven percent higher than she'd expected, well above what she'd budgeted for, and no real understanding of whether that number was even legal in her state or just aggressive. She used the plain-English method from chapter seventeen, the same one she'd have used on the original lease, this time asking specifically about rent increase limits and notice requirements where she lived. The answer didn't tell her the increase was illegal, it wasn't, but it did surface that her state required sixty days' written notice for an increase of that size, and her landlord had given her forty-one. That single fact, found in ten minutes on a Tuesday night, became the actual opening line of the conversation she had with him the following week, a conversation that ended with an extra month at the old rate while she found a plan, not the increase disappearing entirely, but a real, concrete win she wouldn't have known to ask for otherwise.

31.3 October: Linda

October brought Hal's kidney scan follow-up from chapter six, the appointment Linda prepared for the night before with a plain-English explanation and five sharp questions. It went the way chapter six described: real answers instead of a vague sense of relief, a monitoring schedule instead of just "we'll keep an eye on it." The same month, the anniversary trip from chapter three finally got booked, the one Linda's daughter had been gently

pushing for two months before this book even opened. Three destination options in one evening, a hotel narrowed down and verified the next, and an actual booking made in under an hour spread across two sittings, versus the four abandoned browser tabs that had represented the entire previous attempt.

October also delivered the phone call from chapter nine, the voice that sounded exactly like her fifteen-year-old grandson, panicked, asking for bail money. Linda's pause, her habit of checking the story against what she actually knew rather than the tone of the voice, caught it in under a minute. She told Rose about it at their next call, unprompted, the same instinct that had her walking Rose through the billing letter now extending naturally into walking her through the family password idea from chapter nine, before either of them needed it.

Real life doesn't arrive in isolated chapters. It arrives as a season, tasks overlapping and interrupting each other, some of it planned and some of it not, all of it happening to the same tired person at the same kitchen table.

31.4 October: Marisol

Marisol's washing machine, the one from chapter eleven, finally gave out for real in October, not the slow decline she'd been nursing along but a full stop mid-cycle on a Saturday morning with two kids' worth of laundry piled up. The narrow-then-verify method got her from forty options to two finalists in fifteen minutes, verified against real reviews and the actual retailer's current price before buying, delivered and running within the week. The same month, her mother's confusing phone call, the "grandson" asking for money that turned out to be nothing, the wrong number's actual grandmother, not a scam at all this time, but close enough to it that Marisol used the moment to finally have the scam-awareness conversation from chapter nine with her mother, two states away, the script she'd prepared reshaped into her own warmer, funnier words before she ever said them out loud.

31.5 November: both households

November was job-search month for Marisol, the promotion posting from chapter sixteen appearing at exactly the moment her rent situation made a raise genuinely necessary rather than just nice to have. Six years of stale résumé bullet points got translated into the posting's actual language over one focused evening, every claim checked against the interview-room test before it went anywhere near an application. She didn't get that specific role. She got a different one, at a different company, three weeks later, using the same rewritten résumé translated a second time for a different posting, the method reusable the moment it existed rather than a one-time fix for one specific job.

Linda's November was quieter and heavier: the downsizing schedule's fifth Saturday, sorting through Hal's father's old letters and photographs in the room that had been "later" for over a year. No AI tool touched that Saturday at all, and it's worth saying so plainly. Some tasks are entirely and correctly human, no shortcut available or wanted, and the book that pretended otherwise about every single task in a life would be lying about what it's actually for.

31.6 December: both households

December closed the season with two small, unplanned things that mattered more than their size. Marisol's mother, on her own initiative for the first time, asked her phone how to substitute an ingredient she was missing for a holiday recipe she'd made for thirty years without ever needing help before, the same small, unprompted, entirely hers moment chapter thirty named as the real measure of whether teaching someone actually worked. And Linda, wrapping presents on a quiet Tuesday night in December, used the hobby method from chapter nineteen for the first time all season on something that wasn't a chore at all: a simple watercolor card for her granddaughter, badly painted, entirely her own, no problem attached to it whatsoever.

Month	Linda's household	Marisol's household
Sept	Mattress refund re-solved; downsizing schedule begins	Lease renewal; rent-increase notice rule found
Oct	Kidney scan appointment; trip booked; grandson scam call caught	Washing machine replaced; mother's scare becomes a scam-safety talk
Nov	Downsizing's fifth Saturday, no AI at all	Résumé rewritten; new job offer
Dec	Watercolor card for granddaughter	Mother asks AI unprompted, for the first time

FIGURE 31.1. *How one season actually unfolded for both households, side by side: overlapping, uneven, and never as tidy as four calendar months make it look.*

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- Real use of everything in this book looks uneven, not tidy: a schedule that survives a missed Saturday, a habit that spreads sideways to a sister or a mother without being taught on purpose, a task where no shortcut belongs at all.
- The habits compound. Marisol's résumé method, learned once for one posting, worked again unchanged for a second one weeks later.
- Some tasks stay entirely, correctly human. This book was never arguing otherwise, and a season that included one is more honest than one that didn't.
- The smallest moments, an unprompted question, a badly painted card, are usually the real measure of whether any of this actually took root.

31.7 Where this goes next

Chapter thirty-two adds up what a season like this one is actually worth, in the two currencies that matter most: the hours it gave back, and the money it saved or protected along the way.

CHAPTER 32

The Time and Money It Actually Saves

This book has avoided a big, round, satisfying number for a reason: “AI saves the average person eleven hours a week” sounds impressive and means almost nothing, because it isn’t measuring your week, your tasks, or your actual life. What follows instead is smaller and more honest, an accounting of the specific things that changed across the one season chapter thirty-one just walked through, added up the way you’d actually add up a season, not the way a marketing claim would.

32.1 The time, counted plainly

Trip planning, chapter three’s sixteen-hour average research burden, compressed to under an hour of Linda’s actual evening. The complaint letter that would have sat unwritten for who knows how much longer than its actual eleven days, resolved in an afternoon once the words finally came. Diego’s homework sessions, no measurable time saved on any single evening, but a real, ongoing reduction in the dread that used to precede every single one of them, which is its own kind of cost even when it doesn’t show up on a clock. The washing machine, forty options collapsed to two finalists in fifteen minutes instead of an entire evening lost to unreadable spec sheets. None of these are dramatic on their own. Stacked across one season, across two households, they’re the difference between a fall that felt manageable and one that felt like it was constantly catching up.

The honest accounting includes an acknowledgment that the biggest parts of what changed this season aren't on this page at all.

32.2 The money, counted just as plainly

Some of it is direct: the full mattress refund Linda would very plausibly have given up chasing after a frustrating enough phone call, the extra month at the old rent Marisol negotiated because she knew the actual notice-period rule before the conversation instead of during it. Some of it is closer to money not lost than money gained, which counts just as much even though it's less visible: the wire transfer Linda never sent to a voice that sounded exactly like her grandson, the washing machine bought at a genuinely competitive price because narrowing the field left real time to compare instead of grabbing whatever was in front of her at the store. None of this is a return-on-investment chart. It's closer to what chapter seven's Federal Reserve statistic pointed at back in that chapter: a real, sizable share of people are one unexpected few hundred dollars away from real trouble, and both the refund and the averted scam landed, for these two households, inside exactly that margin.

32.3 A rough tally, for anyone who wants a number anyway

If a number genuinely helps make this concrete, here's an honest, conservative one, built only from the tasks this book actually walked through, not a marketing estimate: the trip planning alone (chapter three) saved somewhere in the neighborhood of fourteen hours against the sixteen-hour average. The washing machine comparison (chapter eleven) saved most of an evening. The Thanksgiving timeline (chapter twenty-one) likely saved several hours spread across the week before, hard to pin to a single number precisely because it was spread so thin. Add those three alone, from a single season, and it's a genuine day or more of time back, before counting anything else in this chapter at all, which is exactly the point: the number

was never the headline. It was always going to be an honest byproduct of a lot of small, ordinary tasks done a little less painfully.

32.4 Try this: tally your own week

The rough tally above is Linda’s and Marisol’s, not yours, and the point was never to borrow their number. Pick one real week, and after each task in this book you actually try, jot down two things: about how long the old way would have taken, and about how long it actually took. Nothing fancy, a phone note is enough.

Task	Old way	This week

FIGURE 32.1. A blank week’s tally. Photocopy it, or just copy the three columns onto a phone note, and fill it in as the week actually happens, not from memory afterward.

Three weeks of this, and you’ll have your own honest number, built from your own actual tasks, worth more than any average this chapter or anyone else could print.

32.5 What doesn’t show up on either list

Some of what changed across the season resists being counted at all, and it would be dishonest to pretend otherwise just to round out a tidy

chapter. Rose sounding steadier on the phone after twenty minutes with a confusing letter isn't a number. Marisol's mother asking her own question, unprompted, for the first time, isn't a number either. Hal's slow, genuine change of heart about a toast he'd have otherwise dreaded giving isn't measurable in hours or dollars, and trying to force it into either column would flatten something that mattered more than either column can hold. The honest accounting includes an acknowledgment that the biggest parts of what changed this season aren't on this page at all.

32.6 What this chapter is not claiming

This isn't a claim that AI makes anyone richer or gives anyone more hours in a day, and a book that promised that would be lying in exactly the way chapter one promised, on its first page, this book wouldn't. It's a claim much smaller and much more defensible: that a specific set of ordinary tasks, done with the habits this book teaches, tend to cost less time, less money, and less quiet dread than the same tasks done the old way, staring at a blank box, guessing, or avoiding them entirely. Some weeks that difference is barely noticeable. Some weeks, the way chapter fourteen's dark Tuesday or chapter nine's early morning phone call showed, it's the difference that actually matters.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- The value here isn't one big round number. It's a season's worth of specific, smaller savings: hours of research compressed, dread reduced even when time wasn't, money kept rather than lost.
- Money not lost, an averted scam, a fee successfully disputed, counts every bit as much as money gained, even though it's harder to see on a page.
- Some of what matters most, a sister sounding steadier, a mother's first unprompted question, resists being counted at all. That doesn't make it smaller. It makes it the part a spreadsheet was never going to capture.
- The honest claim is modest: less time, less money, less dread, on the ordinary tasks this book covers. Not a bigger life. Just a somewhat lighter one, most weeks.

32.7 Where this goes next

Chapter thirty-three is where this book stops making its own case and lets the honest pushback in: the real questions and real doubts a book like this owes its reader a straight answer to, not just the ones it's comfortable answering.

CHAPTER 33

Questions You Still Have

Every chapter in this book has made its own case, one task at a time. This one stops making the case and answers the pushback directly, the questions a friend would actually ask over coffee if you told them you'd started using AI for things like this, not the softened version a book usually pretends its reader is thinking.

KEY INSIGHT

Half of U.S. adults say the growing use of AI in daily life makes them feel more concerned than excited, and only about one in ten say the reverse. That's not a fringe reaction this book needs to talk you out of. It's the majority position, and a book that didn't take it seriously wouldn't deserve your trust on anything else in it.

Source: Pew Research Center, "How Americans View AI and Its Impact on People and Society," 2025.

33.1 “Isn’t this just cheating, or being lazy?”

Chapter five drew this line as carefully as any in the book: using AI to produce a finished thing you claim as entirely your own unaided work, an essay, a claim on a résumé, a personal story you didn't live, is dishonest, full stop. Using it to get past a blank page, translate confusing language, or ask

the questions a good tutor would ask isn't laziness any more than using a calculator for long division is. The honest test, used throughout this book: could you explain and defend every part of the final result yourself. If yes, you did the work. The tool just removed some friction on the way.

33.2 “Will this make me worse at thinking for myself?”

This is the most serious question in this chapter, and the honest answer has real teeth: yes, if you let it. Chapter eight's whole argument was built around exactly this risk, research showing people accept a confidently wrong AI answer four times out of five. The habit that protects against it, checking the one fact that would actually matter if it were wrong, is real work you have to keep doing, not a one-time fix. This book isn't arguing the risk away. It's arguing that the risk is manageable with one specific habit, practiced consistently, not that it doesn't exist.

This book isn't arguing the risk away. It's arguing that the risk is manageable with one specific habit, practiced consistently, not that it doesn't exist.

33.3 “Is what I type actually private?”

Chapter ten covered this directly: not by default, on most tools, though every major one has a setting to turn off using your conversations to train their systems. Treat anything you type the way you'd treat a call center employee reading it off a screen somewhere, not a stranger on the street, but not a locked diary either. None of the tasks in this book require your full account numbers or a child's full name and school together. That's not an accident. It's a boundary worth keeping on purpose.

33.4 “What if I don’t have a smartphone or reliable internet?”

This book has quietly assumed a smartphone or computer and a working internet connection the whole way through, and it’s worth naming that assumption rather than pretending it doesn’t exist. If that’s not your situation, most public libraries have free computers, internet access, and increasingly, staff specifically trained to help with exactly this kind of task. It’s a real gap this book can’t close on its own, and pretending otherwise would be dishonest.

33.5 “Isn’t this just another subscription I don’t need?”

No. Every task in this book was done on a free account. Chapter ten said this plainly and it’s worth repeating here: the paid tiers buy speed and higher limits, not better help with anything this book covers. Nobody needs to spend a dollar to use any habit in this book.

33.6 “What about my grandkids growing up with this instead of real skills?”

A fair worry, and chapter five’s answer applies here too, at a longer time horizon: the line between a tutor asking questions and a machine handing over finished answers is the whole difference, and it’s worth teaching kids that line explicitly, early, rather than hoping they find it on their own. This book can’t promise every kid will land on the right side of it without an adult actively teaching it, the same way it can’t promise a kid won’t cheat on a test with a hidden note. What it can say is that the tool itself doesn’t decide which side of the line a kid ends up on. How the adults around them use and talk about it does.

33.7 “Won’t this take someone’s job?”

Somewhere, for some kinds of work, probably yes, and a book aimed at helping you use these tools for your own kitchen table shouldn’t pretend that larger question away just because it’s uncomfortable. That’s a real, serious economic question this book, about ordinary personal tasks, isn’t equipped to resolve, and anyone telling you it’s simple in either direction is oversimplifying something genuinely complicated.

33.8 “What if it says something offensive or just weird?”

It happens, rarely, and when it does, the honest response is the same as with a person who said something odd: don’t treat it as gospel, don’t escalate, just redirect or start over. These tools are not infallible or perfectly calibrated, and nothing in this book has claimed otherwise.

33.9 “Do I need to talk to it differently than I talk to a person?”

Less than you’d think, and chapter two’s whole argument was built around exactly this: talk to it the way you’d talk to a genuinely patient person who doesn’t know your specific situation yet and needs you to fill them in. No special commands, no secret syntax. Plain, specific, and honest gets you further than clever every time.

33.10 “What if I ask it something and later find out it was wrong?”

Chapter eight’s habit exists for exactly this moment: check the one fact that would actually matter before you act on it, not after. When it does happen anyway, despite checking, that’s not proof the whole approach failed. It’s proof the check matters, the way a single wrong measurement doesn’t disprove the value of a tape measure.

Question	Honest answer
Isn't this just cheating?	Only if you claim it as unaided work you couldn't defend yourself
Will this make me worse at thinking for myself?	Yes, if you let it. One habit, checking the fact that matters, keeps that from happening
Is what I type actually private?	Not by default, but every major tool lets you turn training use off

FIGURE 33.1. *Three of this chapter’s own questions and their honest one-line answers, for whoever needs the short version before the long one.*

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- Half of Americans feel more concerned than excited about AI’s growing role in daily life. This book takes that seriously rather than arguing you out of it.
- The real risks named across this chapter, dishonesty, over-reliance, privacy, a widening skills gap for kids, a genuine economic question this book can’t resolve, are all real. The answer to each is a specific habit or boundary, not a claim that the risk doesn’t exist.
- Every task in this book works on a free account, on a smartphone or computer with ordinary internet access. Where that access itself is the barrier, a public library is a genuine, practical answer.
- Honest doubt about a technology this new is the reasonable position, not a character flaw this book is trying to argue you out of.

33.11 Where this goes next

The last chapter is the one to actually keep: every exact prompt and template from every chapter in this book, collected in one place, by the kitchen table.

CHAPTER 34

The Toolkit

This chapter has no story in it. It's the reference page this book has been quietly promising all along: every exact prompt and template from every chapter, collected in one place, so you never have to flip back through thirty-three chapters hunting for the one sentence you actually needed. Photocopy it, screenshot it, tear these pages out if this is a physical copy. It's meant to be used, not admired.

Every template below follows the same underlying rule, chapter two's rule, restated one final time because it's the one thing worth remembering if you remember nothing else: be specific about who it's for, what actually matters, and what to avoid or watch out for, the way you'd be specific with a person standing next to you and not a search box. Fill in the brackets with your own real situation. The words around the brackets are a starting point, not a script to recite exactly.

34.1 The one sentence underneath everything (Chapter 2)

"I need [specific thing], for [who it's actually for / the real situation], and it needs to [what actually matters here], but not [what to avoid]."

34.2 Planning something (Chapter 3)

“We want [a trip / an event] for [timeframe], [key details: number of people, budget, dates]. We care about [what actually matters to you]. Give me [2-4] options and why each one fits.”

34.3 The stuck letter (Chapter 4)

Before typing anything: who is this going to, what outcome do you actually want, and what tone are you going for. Then: “I need to write a [firm/formal/warm] message about [situation, with dates and facts in order]. I want [the specific outcome]. Write it [tone], and end with [a specific next step or deadline].”

34.4 The homework tutor (Chapter 5)

“My [age]-year-old is working on [subject/assignment]. Don’t give the answer directly. Ask one question at a time to help them figure it out themselves, and adjust the difficulty based on how they respond.”

34.5 Before a doctor’s appointment (Chapter 6)

“I have an appointment about [symptom or finding, described specifically]. Help me understand what I’ve described in plain English if there’s anything confusing about it, and give me [4-5] specific questions to make sure I ask so I don’t leave more confused than I came in.”

34.6 A plain-English money question (Chapter 7)

“Explain [the specific term or document] like I’ve never seen this before. Then help me think through [the specific decision or comparison], not by telling me what to pick, but by telling me what actually matters here.”

34.7 The two-question check, before you act on anything (Chapter 8)

Ask yourself, not the AI tool: What's the one fact in this answer that, if wrong, would actually matter? Have I checked that one fact anywhere else? If you can't answer both honestly, check before you act, not after.

34.8 The scam-safety rule (Chapter 9)

If anyone calls, texts, or emails asking for money, gift cards, or account information urgently, especially a family emergency: hang up or stop replying, then contact that person directly through a number or method you already know and trust, never the number that contacted you. Agree on a family password in advance for genuine emergencies.

34.9 Setting up your tool, and talking instead of typing (Chapter 10)

Download one well-known free app. Find the privacy setting (usually under Settings, Privacy, or Data Controls) and turn off training use if it bothers you. Fill in the "memory" or "custom instructions" setting once with a few standing facts about your situation. Look for a microphone or waveform icon near the message box for voice typing or a full spoken conversation. Search "voice typing" or "voice mode" in your phone's settings if neither is obvious.

34.10 A big purchase (Chapter 11)

"I need to buy [item] within [timeframe], budget around [amount], mainly for [how you'll actually use it]. What actually matters for my situation, what's just marketing, and what do people commonly get wrong buying this kind of thing?" Then verify the finalists yourself: recent reviews, actual current price, any relevant recall.

34.11 The words you can't find (Chapter 12)

Start with three specific, true, unpolished things: a memory, a detail only you would know, what you actually feel, stated plainly. Then: "Help me find the shape connecting these three things into something I could actually say out loud or send." Rewrite anything that doesn't sound like you.

34.12 The weekly reset (Chapter 13)

"Here's what's actually on my plate this week: [list it messily]. Help me sort this into what actually needs to happen this week versus what can wait, and suggest an order to tackle it in."

34.13 The ordinary emergency (Chapter 14)

State the situation, the constraint (a clock, what you have access to), and ask for the next step: "[Situation], I have [time constraint / what you have]. What should I do right now?" For an actual medical emergency, call emergency services first, always.

34.14 When someone you love won't try (Chapter 15)

Stop pitching it as a topic. Use it visibly in your own life. When they ask, answer only the specific question in front of them and stop there. If the door never opens, being the person they can still call is a real, acceptable outcome.

34.15 The job search, translate-don't-invent (Chapter 16)

"Here's my résumé and the job posting I'm applying for. Rewrite my experience to speak directly to what this posting asks for, using only things that

are actually true about my background. Then help me draft a short cover letter in a genuine, non-generic voice.” Apply the interview-room test to every line before sending: could you defend this claim, in detail, to someone’s face?

34.16 The fine print, five things (Chapter 17)

“This is a [lease/contract/agreement] I’m considering. In plain English, what are the five most important things I should understand, especially anything unusual, before I sign?”

34.17 The exact-symptom tech fix (Chapter 18)

“My [device/app] was working fine until [what changed]. Now [exactly what happens, word for word if there’s an error message]. What’s the most likely cause and what should I try first?”

34.18 Something just for you (Chapter 19)

“I’ve never [tried this] before and want to learn just for fun, no pressure. What’s the minimum I need to get started, and walk me through one simple first attempt I could try this week.”

34.19 The plan-comparison prompt (Chapter 20)

“I’m comparing [insurance/Medicare plan options]. My situation is [honest specifics: age, health needs, current plan]. In plain English, what’s the real difference between these options, and what questions should I bring to [a counselor / HR / the plan’s help line] to actually decide?”

34.20 A big gathering's timeline (Chapter 21)

"I'm hosting [event] for [number] people, including [any dietary restrictions]. Help me build a full timeline for the day, what to cook or do when so everything's ready together, and a shopping or supply list organized by what needs to happen ahead versus at the last minute."

34.21 The caregiving organizer (Chapter 22)

"I'm helping care for [family member]. Here's the current situation: [medications, appointments, or concerns, described honestly]. Help me organize this into a clear, shareable [schedule / summary / calendar] I can use myself and share with other family members helping out."

34.22 The financial aid process-orientation prompt (Chapter 23)

"We're starting to think about college and financial aid for [student's grade level]. In plain English, what's the realistic timeline, what do the major terms mean, and what should we actually be doing now versus later?"

34.23 The natural-translation prompt (Chapter 24)

"Translate this explanation into natural, conversational [language], the way you'd actually explain it to someone, not a stiff, literal translation." For anything with real legal or medical weight, treat the result as a starting point and ask for a professional human interpreter.

34.24 The pet-symptom prompt (Chapter 25)

"My [pet, age, general health] has [symptom, how long, anything else notable]. I have/don't have a vet appointment [timeframe]. Is this the kind

of thing worth an earlier appointment, and what questions should I bring?” For anything that reads as a possible emergency, call an emergency vet line directly instead.

34.25 The paycheck and withholding prompt (Chapter 26)

“Here’s my pay stub, explain each line in plain English.” Or: “I got a raise and my tax refund was unusually large this year. In plain English, what does a W-4 form actually control, and what questions should I answer for myself before adjusting it?”

34.26 The plain-English estate-planning prompt (Chapter 27)

“I’m [your situation: age, family structure, whether you have existing documents]. In plain English, what’s the difference between a will, a health-care directive, and [other relevant document], and what personal decisions should I think through before meeting with a lawyer?”

34.27 The repair-estimate prompt (Chapter 28)

“My mechanic gave me this estimate for [the symptom, described specifically]: [list the actual line items]. In plain English, what do these mean, does this fix match my symptom, and is this price reasonable?”

34.28 The bare-bones-budget prompt (Chapter 29)

“I was just laid off, [notice period], [number of dependents], [rough monthly expenses]. In plain English, help me build a bare-bones budget for the next three months assuming no income, and walk me through what unemployment benefits typically cover and how to apply in [your state].”

34.29 Teaching someone else, the first lesson (Chapter 30)

“Show me something you’ve been wanting to ask or figure out, doesn’t matter how small. Let’s type it together, you hold the phone, I’ll just help if you get stuck.” Whoever has the problem holds the phone and does the typing, every time.

The words around the brackets are a starting point, not a script to recite exactly.

34.30 The three questions to ask yourself before any of the above

Regardless of which template you reach for, these three questions, first named in chapter two, sit underneath every one of them:

- Who is this actually for, or what’s the real situation?
- What actually matters here, stated as a specific goal?
- What should it avoid, or what boundary matters?

Answer those three honestly, in your own words, before you type anything, and most of what makes a request vague instead of useful disappears on its own.

The question	Your answer
Who is this actually for, or what's the real situation?	
What actually matters here, stated as a specific goal?	
What should it avoid, or what boundary matters?	

FIGURE 34.1. *The three questions from chapter two, blank and ready to photocopy: fill them in honestly before you type anything, for any task in this book or any one it doesn't cover.*

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- Every template in this book follows the same underlying rule from chapter two: specific, not vague, the way you'd be specific with a person and not a search box.
- The brackets are yours to fill in with your real situation. Nothing here is meant to be typed word for word.
- Keep this chapter somewhere you'll actually find it again: a bookmark, a photo on your phone, a sticky note by the computer.
- If you remember only one thing from this whole book, make it the three questions above. Everything else is that one habit, aimed at a different Tuesday.

About the Author

James Liu has spent years building AI products in Silicon Valley and at major technology companies, including ByteDance. He holds a Bachelor of Computing in Computer Science from the National University of Singapore, awarded with distinction with a specialization in artificial intelligence, and spent a year at Stanford University.